

The Sati Journal

The Journal of the Sati Center for Buddhist Studies

WOMEN'S CONTRIBUTIONS TO BUDDHISM: SELECTED PERSPECTIVES

VOLUME TWO

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Volume 2



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Cover photo: Gandhara relief depicting the birth of the Buddha, 2nd century CE.

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Editorial

NONA OLIVIA

In the fall of 2011, I was delighted when Gil Fronsdal and Jeff Hardin asked me to be the guest editor for an issue devoted to women in Buddhism. As it happened, due to responsibilities as a mother and grandmother, spending time with my dying stepmother, attending to my own and others' illnesses, developing a curriculum and overseeing its implementation, traveling to international conferences, and continuing my own Buddhist practice, the project encountered numerous delays. I mention this not as an excuse or justification, but as an example of what ordinary women routinely encounter in their lives.

Historically and culturally, up to today, women are usually the first responders to the needs of their families, communities, and jobs. It is humbling to see women meet all their daily demands and still be able to engage in creative projects. It is relevant to the theme of this issue to reflect on how much women accomplish and how many people they aspire to serve whether or not they receive any recognition for their efforts.

Until recently, anyone who enquired into the history of Buddhism soon realized how difficult it was to find information about the lives and contributions of Buddhist women. The few exceptions proved the rule. Although some schools of Buddhism celebrate female goddesses, the "divine feminine," and the consorts of male teachers, ordinary women have generally been overlooked. What else but the demands of daily life might have overshadowed women's contributions to Buddhism?

One factor is that in many cultures, it is considered unseemly for women to draw attention to themselves or their accomplishments. Buddhists, even those training in mindfulness and compassion, both in the past and present, are quick to rebuke as egotistic or "reifying a sense of self" a woman (not necessarily a man) who seeks acknowledgment for her work. Scholars and practitioners investigating the history of women in Bud-

dhism have noticed this lacuna and, over the past few decades, momentum for studying the lives of eminent women in Buddhism has been growing.

Over the past thirty years especially, there has been a slow but steady increase of interest in recognizing and supporting the struggles and accomplishments of Buddhist women. In the 1970s, scholars such as Diana Paul, Nancy Auer Falk, Bhikkhunī Dhammanandā (Chatsumarn Kabilsingh), and Rita Gross began to examine the history of women in Buddhism, laying the foundation of methodologies with which to study those omitted from history. Monastic women, such as Ayya Khemā, Karma Lekshe Tsomo, and Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo began examining the inequalities, cultural impediments, and the often dire living conditions of Buddhist nuns – revelations that fueled growing interest and support. Lay Buddhist women in the west, notably Ruth Denison, Sharon Salzburg, Joan Halifax, and Christina Feldman, put their efforts into teaching and building community practice centers. Happily, these women have inspired many others, both women and men. A new generation of women, full of enthusiasm for Dharma study and practice, enjoys opportunities that will ensure the continuity of these important advances.

Still, there are some for whom the issue of gender and women's contributions to Buddhism seem irrelevant. These detractors believe that Buddhists need only focus on meditation and argue that the issue of gender is a distraction from the goal of reaching enlightenment. To these detractors we may respond by pointing out what we've learned from civil rights scholars and activists – that those who enjoy privilege, recognition, and support for their endeavors are often blind to the needs and struggles of others. In this issue, Rita Gross makes a stunningly simple observation: if gender is not an issue, as many Buddhist teachers claim, then discussing it should be no problem.

This issue of the *Sati Journal* approaches the topic of women in Buddhism through the lens of three overlapping themes: early Buddhist scholars, symbolic representations of gender, and inspiring contemporary leaders. The issue begins with an essay by Rita Gross, whose well-known 1992 book, *Buddhism After Patriarchy*, introduced many readers to the study of gender in Buddhism for the first time. In her endorsement of this book,

Joanna Macy wrote, "The book will fill a real, indeed urgent need and be of great service to many Buddhists and students, scholars and friends of Buddhism." After a forty-year career in the Department of Comparative Studies in Religion at the University of Wisconsin–Eau Claire, Rita Gross has been recognized by Khandro Rinpoche as a Dharma teacher (*lobön*) in the Vajrayāna lineage.

Caroline Rhys Davids is the subject of the essay by Dawn Neal, a student of mine in the M.A. program at the Sati Institute's program at the Institute of Buddhist Studies. Neal's research focuses on the life and contributions of the nineteenth-century British scholar who translated and wrote more than twenty books based on the Pāli Canon. Rhys Davids lived and worked at a time when very few women were acknowledged for their scholarship. She was also a wife and mother, a fact which makes her prolific writing all the more exceptional. Rhys Davids gave us the first translation of the *Therīgāthā* and her groundbreaking work continues to be cited in scholarship today.

Ajahn Amaro is the author of the next essay, a short anecdotal biography of I. B. Horner, who was his cousin. I. B. Horner, a student of Caroline A. F. Rhys Davids and her husband T. W. Rhys Davids, is perhaps best known for her seminal work, *Women Under Primitive Buddhism*. In her Oxford Bibliography article on "Feminist Approaches to the Study of Buddhism," Lori Meeks writes that "Caroline A. F. Rhys Davids and I. B. Horner are commonly recognized as the founders of Anglo-American scholarship on women in Buddhism. Rhys Davids and Horner, both leading members of the Pāli Text Society, were first and foremost philologists. While their political interests may have informed their decisions to study women in Buddhism, they did not convey overtly feminist aims in their writings." Isaline Blew Horner served as president of the Pāli Text Society and was awarded Order of the British Empire by Queen Elizabeth for her many years of research on Buddhism.

The next contributor, Bhikkhu Anālayo , is perhaps best known for his 2003 translation and commentary, *Satipaṭṭhāna: The Direct Path to Realization*. He has published numerous books and articles and is a popular speaker, author, and Buddhist teacher. He is also an outspoken supporter of full ordination for women. His essay focuses on a verse from the

Therīgāthā, the collection of verses attributed to seventy nuns who were ordained at the time of the Buddha. In this essay, Bhikkhu Anālayo examines the tale of a young nun named Subhā and a young man's attempt to seduce her, applying his knowledge of a similar tale from the Chinese *Āgamas* to examine the gender significance conveyed in the verses.

Next, Noa Ronkin applies her philological skills to parse the uses of the Pāli word *mātikā*, a gendered term that is often translated as "mother." In this essay, she examines the way the word is used in the *Abhidhamma*. She is the author of *Early Buddhist Metaphysics: The Making of a Philosophical Tradition* (Routledge-Curzon, 2005) and various articles on the *Abhidhamma* tradition. After receiving a PhD from the University of Oxford, Ronkin taught and worked as a research fellow at the Center for Buddhist Studies at Stanford University. In addition to being the mother of two small children, she is currently an independent scholar and also works for a nonprofit tech company that develops technology focused on social good.

An essay on the completion of life is a fitting end to this issue. Jetsunma Tenzin Palmo is a living example of an inspiring contemporary leader and we feel that including her makes clear the continuity of outstanding women in Buddhism. Here she shares a paper on ageing that she presented at the 2013 Sakyadhita International Conference on Buddhist Women in Vaishali, India. Jetsunma is perhaps best known for spending twelve years in a cave high in the Himalayas. Her work continued when she left that solitude and returned to the busy world, fulfilling her teacher's request to create a place where women could be fully trained as *togdenmas* (realized ones). She currently heads the Dongyu Gatsal Ling Nunnery that she founded in Himachal Pradesh, India, where over seventy girls and young women are receiving the education and training usually reserved for monks. Her essay reflects her very pragmatic approach to getting things done, as seen in her comment about ageing: "We are reborn to a new life without yet having to discard the old one!"

I am grateful to the authors for submitting articles of such high caliber, which shed light on our current understanding and create a foundation for future scholarship on the topic of women in Buddhism. I thank the

authors for their patience with getting this issue to the public, who will benefit richly from their efforts.

In acknowledgment, I would like to express my appreciation to the Sati Board of Directors: Gil Fronsdal, Jeff Hardin, Carolyn Dille, Lori Wong, Richard Shankman, Steve Gasner, Robert Cusick and Tony Bernard for their friendship and support. I am grateful to Barbara Ryan for her continued generosity and to Bhikkhu Ṭhānissaro for his keen attention to each piece. Thanks go to Diana Wilde for her work on the cover.

I am deeply grateful to Ajahn Pasanno for his teachings and his exemplary practice of right speech. And words cannot express my awe and gratitude to Venerable Lekshe Tsomo for being the compassionate and fearless proponent of support for Buddhist women.

Especially, I would like to thank the many women—lay and monastic, past and present—who have worked tirelessly, often unacknowledged and unappreciated, to preserve, teach, and serve the Dharma. You are my inspiration.

I would like to dedicate this issue of *Sati Journal* in honor of Māyā Devī, the mother of the historical Buddha, who died seven days after his birth. Although she appears to be a footnote in the annals of Buddhist history, without her, Buddhism would not exist. For this reason we have chosen an image of her for the cover of this volume.

How Clinging to Gender Subverts Enlightenment

RITA M. GROSS

Most forms of Buddhism adhere to teachings of egolessness, asserting that there is no permanent abiding self beneath the flux of experience, despite our deep-seated emotional reaction that there *must* be such a thing because it feels so real. Buddhist teachings also claim that much of our suffering is caused by our grasping to that non-existent, but very deceptive idea of a self. Enlightenment, peace, unbinding—whatever words one uses to convey the whole point of Buddhist view and practice—require that one lay down the burden of constantly trying to constitute a self, an enduring and reliable identity, out of the kaleidoscope of our experience. Thus, it seems that the Buddha intended us to take this business of egolessness with utmost seriousness.

One should wonder, then, why Buddhists have been so shy about questioning the centrality we attribute to gender in our everyday lives and so oblivious to the overbearing importance gender plays in Buddhist institutional life. No other element of experience has such a stranglehold on our immediate reactions to people we meet, conditioning how we view them and making it impossible for us to simply encounter them freshly, free of preconceptions and prejudice. Such everyday reactivity might not be completely devastating had it not been elevated into the supreme organizing principle of traditional Buddhist institutional life. Not only do Buddhist institutions such as educational centers, meditation centers, and monastic orders traditionally practice sexual segregation; they also practice gender hierarchy, with the result that men's practice and education has always been much better supported economically and emotionally than have women's practice and education. No wonder the view that female rebirth is unfortunate compared to male rebirth grew ever stronger, and in many parts of the Buddhist world, eventual rebirth as a male was presented as the only viable solution to the misfortunes of female rebirth.

The fact that many North American Buddhists are unaware of these traditional attitudes and practices does nothing to cancel these facts about traditional Buddhism or make them irrelevant. Even if that were the case, Western Buddhists have a moral obligation to be aware of the devastation this attribution of relevance or reality to gender has wrought in Buddhist life historically and the ways in which it still limits Buddhists in many parts of the world. Furthermore, looking beneath the surface of the superficial equality in the West reveals that sexual stereotypes and fixed notions about gender are alive and well here also.

Buddhists, at least reasonably well educated Buddhists, all affirm egolessness and claim to believe that it accurately describes how things are, even if they don't really understand egolessness and can't explain it. Yet most of them also expect men and women to be different and to have different life plans and expectations. They seem untroubled by the fact that, even in North America, most of the best known and most popular teachers are men. They are uninterested in and even hostile to Buddhist feminist reforms such as lineage chants that include female ancestors, gender-inclusive and gender-neutral liturgies, or specific attention to female role models. In other words, their allegiance to teachings on egolessness has had no impact on their reliance on conventional, everyday gender norms and stereotypes.

For years, I have used a slogan to summarize this situation: *Though there is no permanent abiding self/ego, nevertheless gender is real.* Put even more succinctly, egolessness is gendered—a statement that makes no sense, but a statement that captures the absurdity of clinging to rigid and fixed gender norms while also affirming egolessness. It seems to me that only one element of this motto can actually be adhered to because its two elements are mutually exclusive. Which is more important to us? Egolessness and enlightenment or the security of conventional notions about gender?

The tragedy is that Buddhists have spent a great deal of time and energy deconstructing ego with many sophisticated teachings. One would think that in working so hard to deconstruct ego, Buddhists would have noticed how central a component of ego gender is. Instead, they have spent a comparable amount of time and energy making and

enforcing rules about gender, especially for monastics, and have also acquiesced without comment to the gender norms of the surrounding cultures. But they have usually not put these two enterprises together. They have not questioned why rules and norms about gender should be so important if nothing about the phenomenal self truly exists. Instead, the most commonly invoked statement about gender is the slogan that enlightened mind is neither male nor female, as if that truism by itself undid all the pain and injustice caused by gender norms and stereotypes. Comfortable, even smug in their assurance that gender is ultimately unreal, many Buddhists are then *very* comfortable insisting that everyone conform to conventional gender norms and criticizing those who defy them.

To ensure that enlightenment is not subverted by clinging to gender, we need to bring these two sets of discourse together to analyze their relevance to each other. In the first instance, what is needed is not citation of the absolute—that enlightened mind is beyond gender—but much more discussion at the relative level, many more critical analyses of the relevance and utility of conventional gender norms and practices. For although enlightened mind is beyond male and female, unenlightened minds are decidedly not beyond concern with male and female. I have found in my many years of talking and writing about Buddhism and gender that Buddhists really dislike talking and thinking about gender at this level, perhaps because, apart from its uplifted slogan that enlightened mind is beyond gender, Buddhism's actual record on the practicalities of gender is quite depressing. Nevertheless, many Buddhists will do almost anything to avoid discussion on the practicalities of gender, even shaming and ridiculing those who want to have the discussion.

The basic problem with conventional approaches to gender is that the immediate, often unavoidable, perception that someone is either a man or a woman instantaneously brings with it a whole host of assumptions, expectations, and restrictions. There is obviously no problem with the immediate perception. Gender designations as conventional, agreed-upon labels are harmless and somewhat useful. The problem lies with all the baggage that is imposed on the perception by longstanding training in conventional gender stereotypes. For example, thinking about my own experience, I know that I have a female body and in my

full-figured case, that is quite obvious to others as well. But that really doesn't give people much reliable information about me and no information that conforms me to the stereotypical female gender role. It does not mean that I must bear children, or even that I can. It does not mean that I necessarily have a gentle, non-aggressive demeanor, as opposed to a violent or nasty temperament. It does not even guarantee my primary sexual orientation, which has been guessed wrong almost as often as it has been guessed right by observers, both women and men. My female sex is not a reliable guide to my interests and concerns. I care little for many of the things that are supposed to interest women, but I also am interested in some things that are generally thought to be of more interest to women than to men. In short, though my sex may be the first fact about me that registers, it tells people relatively little about me. Nevertheless, though my female body doesn't translate into anything essential about me, a great deal has been projected onto it by society, by religions, and by individuals who think that the shape of my body reveals something intrinsically existing, something on which it is valid to pin all sorts of meanings and limitations.

Thus, conventional gender norms and stereotypes are essentially useless for determining what any individual is really about. But analysis of gender at the relative level must also discuss the tremendous pain caused by conventional gender norms, a topic that should be of concern to Buddhists who claim that dharma practitioners should attempt to alleviate suffering. In a traditional culture, even a Buddhist culture, I could have been forced into the female gender role in spite of my own capabilities and inner direction. It is devastating to think of how many children, both boys and girls, have been forced into lifestyles to which they were unsuited by conventional gender expectations.

Some parts of my analysis of how clinging to gender subverts enlightenment actually have long been recognized by Buddhists. The easily misunderstood traditional teaching that female rebirth is less fortunate than male rebirth is precisely about the pain of being female in a male-dominated system, a point that is clearly recognized in traditional lists of the woes of female rebirth. In addition to what are assessed as biological liabilities, those lists always include the pain of gender hierarchy and male dominance. This liability has been especially devastating for female

monastics who have long faced reduced economic support, inferior training, and, in some parts of the Buddhist world, extinction of their ordination lineages because traditional Buddhist monastic rules are extreme in the way they favor monks over nuns. In some parts of the Buddhist world in contemporary times, nuns have largely overcome their inferior status, but in other parts of the Buddhist world, monks (and also some laypeople) are trying very hard to keep women from gaining full ordination as monastics. It is hard to understand how otherwise intelligent and compassionate men/monks cannot figure out the legalisms required to initiate or re-instate nuns' ordination lineages, given that if their own ordination lineages were at stake, they would solve the problem in a heartbeat! To justify their unwillingness to ordain women, they argue that deep practice and spiritual attainment are not dependent on status. Therefore, women could attain realization despite their inferior position in the Buddhist world. That argument is correct, of course, though men never apply that logic to themselves, but only to women. There are profound Buddhist teachings on how useful obstacles can be in the long run if they don't destroy one first. But nothing in Buddhist thought suggests that one should deliberately place obstacles in peoples' paths, and there is no doubt that throughout history the nuns' lower status and lack of full ordination has been a great obstacle to their attainments and their very survival. Low status resulting in lack of support for nuns clearly can subvert women's enlightenment. One must also wonder about the spiritual well-being of those who continue to insist that nothing can be done about traditional gender hierarchy. It does seem that ego-grasping is quite alive and well in such a mindset.

So much for ego-grasping and gender as they pertain to the more mundane aspects of Buddhist institutions, lifestyles, and everyday life. What about some of the more profound Buddhist analytical and meditational techniques? The various deconstructive exercises of Buddhism were all designed to challenge students to try to find the insubstantial ego that they took for granted, and not finding that self, discover peace and freedom. In the famous *Mahāmudrā* investigations as well, one explores whether mind can be found in any specific attribute, such as shape or color. In the Pāli suttas, when the Buddha is asked about any specific

element being isolated and analyzed, he often replies, "Recognize that this is not yours, not you. Don't identify with it."

I suggest that, while I have never heard a teacher apply these techniques to deconstructing gender, they could easily be applied to that task, significantly strengthening the deconstruction of ego in the process. Such analyses have the added virtue that gender would be deconstructed on genuinely Buddhist grounds, not just through methods familiar to Western secular feminism. Buddhist analyses break down things that are assumed to be truly existing entities by showing that we can't find them, no matter where we look. To demonstrate, let us work with the *skandhas,* specifically the first *skandha* of form. According to Buddhist analysis, we think we have or are a truly existing self, but upon examination, that turns out not to be the case because the purported self actually consists of five insubstantial components/*skandhas*. Looking at the first *skandha* of form, we see that it, likewise, is not an entity but a composite built of many components. It breaks down into the four great elements, which helps us recognize that having a form does not translate into being a self. Commonly, such analyses also point out that things we often think define the form, such as color or shape, really cannot be found and do not confer truly existing selfhood on the form.

It is curious that traditional analyses using "color" or "shape" to break down our assumption of real selfhood never use the terms "male" or "female" in the same way. This omission allows people to easily believe in egolessness while clinging to conventional gender norms and stereotypes that are rigid, arbitrary, inaccurate, and cruel. Would it not be just as useful to disclaim selfhood based on having a male or female form as it is to disclaim selfhood conferred by color or shape? Would it not be useful to contemplate gender as a composite made out of biology, cultural expectations, and habitual patterns, rather than anything that exists truly and substantially, just as it is useful to deconstruct every other thing that seems to be an entity into its component parts?

I suspect that many Buddhists, while willing to do analyses to recognize that form does not confer selfhood might balk at applying the same rigorous analysis to their male or female forms because gender seems so real to them. But doing so intensifies the deconstructive power

of the analysis, making egolessness much less a theoretical belief and much more an "in your face" reality. Without that additional step, people can easily do the traditional exercises and genuinely believe in egolessness but still be quite attached to gender. The effectiveness of such deconstructive analysis can be demonstrated by the reaction of a sweet young man after a day of my teaching on Buddhism and gender. He said, "Without my mustache and genitals, I'd have no idea who I was." I wanted to shout "Bingo—you've got it!" Consistently going to that place of not knowing who one is would go far to attain the peace of egolessness and freedom from the prison of gender roles.

But if we believe that enlightened mind, the natural state of mind, is beyond gender, why is it important to so rigorously deconstruct gender? When teachers scold students who bring up gender issues by reciting the slogan that enlightenment is beyond gender, or when Buddhists frustrated with feminist critiques of conventional Buddhist gender practices also rely upon this slogan, they are missing an important point. People cannot go to that state of mind beyond gender on the spot anymore than they can just drop self-grasping the first time they hear teachings about egolessness. That transformation takes a great deal of time and effort, and just as training is necessary for people to actually approach egolessness, so training is required to transcend the prison of gender roles. Neither just happens. Additionally, a large percentage of self-grasping is not just ego-grasping. It is grasping at an ego that is deeply conditioned by its residence in a male body or a female body, and for many people the maleness or femaleness of that body takes precedence over its humanity. It is important to grab people where they really live, which for many is not in their form *skandha* anyway. They live intimately with and identify very closely with their gender assignments. Until those attachments are cut, there will be ego-clinging, no matter how much people may believe in egolessness. Giving absolute answers to questions about the relative is very unskillful in the short run, even if such answers are true in the long run.

But to live in the relative world we *need* our gender reference points, some may protest. A well-ordered society requires appropriate, sex-specific behavior for men and women, they may claim. Even if that argument were true, it cannot be translated into an argument that male

dominant gender relationships are good and just. Beyond that, the main problem with current gender arrangements is the rigidity and fixation with which people cling to them—a rigidity and fixation that is incompatible with relaxing into the state of mind beyond gender. To negotiate the relative, gendered world in an ethical and ordered way, we really only need one thing. We need a humane, kind sex ethic, not numerous gender norms and stereotypes telling us how men should be and what women cannot do. The foundations of that sex ethic are already well in place in Buddhism.

If one does not make an ego out of gender, one would still know whether one is a man or a woman, gay, straight, bisexual, transgender—whatever else we may think of. But those identities need to fit very loosely and be very lightly worn. All sense of privilege or deprivation that has developed around one's gender identity, all rigidity regarding proper roles and behaviors for the various genders, must be cut through. We really do need to stop making an ego out of gender. And that may well be more difficult than learning about *skandhas* and other traditional Buddhist deconstructive analyses. Gender may well be the last component of our conditioned, composite, impermanent, ever-changing ego to lose its grip on us. That is how clinging to gender subverts enlightenment. Given the dire consequences of clinging to gender, it really is a tragedy that for so long Buddhists have been blind to how this attachment subverts enlightenment and so unwilling to take seriously the analysis that clinging to gender really is an obstacle to resting in the peacefulness and spaciousness of enlightened mind.

The Life and Contributions of CAF Rhys Davids

DAWN NEAL

I. Introduction

It may surprise Western Buddhists that much of our access to English translations of the Pāli Canon of *Theravāda* Buddhism rests upon the pioneering work of 19th century scholar CAF Rhys Davids. A prolific translator of Pāli literature, CAF Rhys Davids generated many works to which our modern scholarship is indebted. Rhys Davids is best known for the first English translation of the *Therīgāthā*, awakening verses and biographies of early Buddhist women elders, adapted in Susan Murcott's popular text, *The First Buddhist Women.* Today, few people have heard of this prolific translator and scholar. Even fewer realize that Caroline Rhys Davids was a woman, a wife and mother, a popular author, teacher, and mentor for the next generation of Early Buddhist scholars.

I believe Caroline Rhys Davids' contributions as a scholar have been occluded, by both the unorthodox interpretations of Buddhism she espoused in the latter part of her career, and subsequent reactions to her hypotheses. Here, I merely touch upon CAF Rhys Davids' later, iconoclastic ideas. These have been discussed elsewhere. Instead, I begin with a brief biography, and posit a likely demarcation point between her early, meticulous contributions and her later, spiritually integrative and controversial writings. In the second half of this essay, I introduce significant contributions CAF Rhys Davids made to the subject areas of Buddhist psychology, Buddhist philosophy, and textual methodology, and argue her contributions may shape how we understand Buddhism today.

II. Biography

CAF Rhys Davids was born Caroline Augusta Foley in 1857 to a mother who painted watercolors and a father who was a third generation

parish priest. Educated in the vicarage, she developed an intellectual passion that was to last her through life. She studied philosophy, political-economic theory, and psychology at University College, London, where she was one of its first women students (Horner, 1942-43, p. 172). Foley earned her Doctor of Letters, DLitt in Sanskrit, and an MA in Philosophy from University College in 1889[1]. She also won prestigious scholarships in philosophy, and was later elected a fellow of the university.

After graduating, Foley quickly mastered Pāḷi. According to her colleague and friend Mabel Bode, Foley had begun to study Pāḷi in 1884, at Thomas W. Rhys Davids' suggestion (Dean, 1998). Indeed, according to IB Horner, Foley's interest in Buddhism was initially encouraged by TW Rhys Davids, who "lured her by the bait of its women poets and psychology." (1942-43, p. 172). In 1892, Foley published her first paper in Pāli literature, "Women Leaders of the Buddhist Reformation," at the Ninth International Congress of Orientalists (1893, p. 344). Jonathan Walters points out that Bode and Foley were the only two "lady scholars represented" in the Indo-Aryan section of the conference (1994, p. 359). The first women ever to contribute academically, they did not, however, present their own papers. Perhaps in response to biases of the time, their colleague and mentor TW Rhys Davids presented summaries on their behalf (Morgan, 1892, pp. lix, xxx)[2].

As the subject of her paper might suggest, Foley "fearlessly promoted" women's suffrage (Horner, 1942-43, p. 172), a perspective that informed her scholarly understanding of early Buddhist women (Collett, 2006, pp. 72-74). Foley actively supported groups dedicated to working-women's and children's welfare (Waterhouse, 1943, p. 131), causes which remained long-time interests (Olive Schreiner Letters Online). When not engaged with social issues, Caroline Foley was a fearless traveler, "an ardent mountaineer, adventuring forth alone with none but her Swiss

[1] Foley studied Sanskrit with Reinhold Rost, Secretary of the Royal Asiatic Society. The RAS was a prominent publisher of *Pāḷi* scholarship, and later published many of her writings (University of London, 1918-1940).

[2] Foley's full paper, based on Dhammapāla's commentary on the *Therīgāthā,* is published in the conference proceedings. Morgan notes that the Ninth Congress was the "first occasion on which ladies had taken part... by contributing papers and discussing scientific subjects with us" (1892, lix).

guides" (Horner, 1942-43). She was also a talented tennis player and could "beat most others" at billiards (Ross, qtd in Peiris1973, p. 21).

A versatile leader and scholar, Foley became the first secretary of the Pāli Text Society when it was founded in 1881. She was also a founding board member of the *Economic Journal* in 1893 (University of London, 1918-1940), and a contributing writer until 1897 (Dean, 1998, p. 213). During her brief stint as an economic writer, she published "Fashion," an important article for later economic theorists. Her analysis integrated psychology, interpersonal factors, and consumer demand (Fullbrook, 1998). Foley's interest in psychology and interdisciplinary synthesis remained a hallmark of her Pāli scholarship and writings on Buddhism, to which she dedicated the rest of her long career.

A respected scholar in her own right, Caroline Foley married Thomas William Rhys Davids, her colleague, academic advocate, and sometime teacher, in 1894. In *The Western Contribution to Buddhism*, William Pieris reports that an unnamed mutual friend encouraged them, anticipating "a union between two great intellectuals" (1973, p. 20). Their marriage was indeed a fruitful one. In addition to three children, the couple produced a tremendous volume of Pāli translations. Bode described them as enthusiastic, tenacious, and untiring scholars, who exhibited "fidelity to an idea" throughout their "full and busy lives" (1911, pp. 83-84, 86).

During this period, CAF Rhys Davids lectured on Indian Philosophy at Victoria University, Manchester (1910-1913). In 1918, she returned to her alma mater as a highly respected teacher (University of London, 1918-1940). Sir Denison Ross, Director of the University's School of Oriental and African Studies, described her as gifted, "one of the ornaments of the school, attracting students from many countries" (Peiris, 1973, p. 20). Her international appeal is understandable. In addition to her significant scholarship, she was a widely published critic and authored at least nineteen books for a popular audience. A brilliant lecturer, Caroline Rhys Davids inspired the next generation of Pāli scholars, including FL Woodward and Ananda Coomaraswamy.

Despite her many popular books, her chief mark on Buddhist studies was made as an editor, translator, "and controversial explicator of Buddhist texts" (Dean, 1998, p. 214). Many scholars consider her finest work to be her translations of the *Abhidhamma* (p. 215), on which she was recognized as the leading Western authority of her time (Bode, 1911, 85; Dean, 1998, p. 215). One of three large groups of texts, or *Piṭaka*, in the Pāli Canon, the *Abhidhamma Piṭaka* is dedicated to extraordinarily subtle and detailed matrices of mental processes. It is widely regarded to be obtuse, dry, and difficult reading. Using her background in psychology, philosophy, and Indic languages, Rhys Davids translated or co-translated five of the seven books of the *Abhidhamma*, as well as significant commentaries[3]. Two of her translations are still the only English volumes of the *Abhidhamma* available through the Pāli Text Society (Pāli Text Society, 2012). Her other translations include the *Saṃyutta Nikāya*, and the *Dīgha Nikāya* (Library of Congress Online). She is perhaps most widely known today for her "monumental and beautiful translation of the *Therīgāthā*" (Walters J. S., 1994, p. 360), the awakening stories of the earliest Buddhist bhikkhunīs, female monastics. As Alice Collett writes, "Rhys Davids, with Bode... and Horner moved the Indian nuns from invisibility to visibility" (2006, p. 74). Rhys Davids conceived female elders capable of will and exalted religious understanding, despite working in an Orientalist culture "that infantilized the populace of the East, and imagined it, almost incidentally, as male" (ibid)[4].

In 1917, the tragic death of her son in World War I precipitated a turning point in CAF Rhys Davids' life and career. Like many grief stricken parents during the war, Caroline Rhys Davids sought solace in a cultural phenomenon sweeping England at the time: Spiritualism (University of

[3] Dean refers to "all six books of the *Abhidhamma*." There are, however, seven. CAF Rhys Davids edited, translated or co-translated five: *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*(1900), *Vibhanga* (1904), *Kathāvatthu* (1915, with SZ Aung), *Yamaka* (1911, assisted by Mabel Hunt and Mary C. Foley), *Paṭṭhāna* or *Dukapaṭṭhāna* (1906, assisted by Mary Foley and Miss GM Noakes) (Library of Congress Online; WorldCat, 2012). She translated *Abhidhamma* commentaries as well: *Atthasālinī* (with Pe Maung Tin), and *Tikkapaṭṭhāna* (1920).

[4] Collett raises some persuasive points about CAF Rhys Davids' feminist interpretations of women in Pāḷi literature, and the predominant conflation of Pāḷi texts with early Buddhism, which are beyond scope here. Cf Collett, 2006, 73-77.

London, 1918-1940)[5]. From 1917, CAF Rhys Davids began to espouse new doctrinal interpretations in her popular writings, stating that Buddhist doctrine of *anattā*, or no permanent, abiding self, "did not apply to the belief in a changing, growing soul that could... defy death..." (Rhys Davids, qtd in Dean, 1998, p. 220)[6]. This interpretation was a marked shift from her earlier writings. It also diverged from a doctrine common to most forms of Buddhism. CAF Rhys Davids' earlier writings privilege clear, rigorous, scholarship and subtle analysis of mental processes, and convey a nuanced understanding of the *anattā* doctrine (Rhys Davids, 1903, p. 589). Her later work, in contrast, speaks of transmigration of the soul. Some scholarly analysis suggests that this significant shift was due to a "major step" in her evolving spiritual beliefs (Dean, 1998, 217)[7]. My own reading of available primary sources supports this. Furthermore, synopses of her letters suggest that her quest for a more personal theology was precipitated by the loss of her son, "a terrible bereavement" (Ross, qtd in Peiris, 1973, p. 20).

With the death of her husband, TW Rhys Davids, in 1922, Caroline Rhys Davids became president of the Pāli Text Society, a position she held for 20 years. During that time, she mentored IB Horner, who became an eminent Pāli scholar and succeeded her as president. Rhys Davids remained a skilled researcher, translator, and editor.

After the loss of her husband and son, Caroline Rhys Davids' work entered a new phase. Her research reflected a personal quest to assuage her grief by integrating her belief in Spiritualism with her extensive knowledge of Buddhism. Beginning in 1922 or 1923[8], this quest took the form of an earnest search for "the Original Buddhism." In the process, she developed a personal conviction that the Buddha's oral teachings had been fundamentally re-shaped in the very texts she had dedicated decades to translating. She began to publicly advocate her

[5] The University of London holds the Rhys Davids family papers and diaries. Their online catalogue quotes an entry stating that she attended her first Spiritualist meeting in late 1917 or early 1918. See http://catalog.loc.gov/cgi-bin

[6] Her 1917 book was entitled *The Buddhist Principle of Change.*

[7] Cf Alice Collett, "Buddism and Gender," p 71, fn 41.

[8] CAF Rhys Davids estimated 1923 to be the year she began a new, distinct, phase of her work (Rhys Davids, 1928, p6, qtd in Wilkes, 199, p15)

hypotheses in 1927 (Varma, 1971, p. 37), which were soon thereafter vilified by some scholars and Asian monastics. In 1932, *The British Buddhist* ran two pieces, an article by Ariya-Dhamma and an anonymous editorial, both of which "brutally criticized the 'perverse view of the Buddha's teaching'" that her books espoused (Dean, 1998, pp. 223-224). CAF Rhys Davids was well aware she was "stigmatized by Buddhists" (1940, p 873, cited in Dean, 1998, 223). Nonetheless, her spiritual beliefs had changed, and she published increasingly iconoclastic interpretations of "The Buddhist Way."

A forceful and charming presence (Waterhouse, 1943, p. 131), CAF Rhys Davids championed a vision of man "willing a becoming of his own growth" over multiple lifetimes (Rhys Davids, 1940, p. 165), a vision informed by her personal experience of Spiritualism[9]. Her call to "will for a greater welfare for each and all" acknowledged the destructive effects of human will evident in early World War II, while conveying a sense of spiritual optimism to shell-shocked Britons (p. 167). The blending of such spiritual convictions with Buddhist scholarship in her later works has led to subsequent scholarly dismissals of her and all of her writings. Unfortunately, the effect of such dismissals is to devalue her earlier contributions to Buddhist studies, which were extraordinary.

At the time of her death, however, Caroline Rhys Davids was far from dismissed. In her 1942 obituary, William Stede spoke to the range of her work as "an abundance of published research which shows a mind gifted with grace and talent, a power of assimilation and an imagination." Of her later work, he noted that her ideas "have proved and will continue to prove an invaluable stimulus to further research" (p. 268). She had left later generations of Buddhist scholars ample material to work with. By 1942, every contemporary journal of Eastern philosophy and religion had published her work (p. 268). She had been directly involved in translating more than twenty books of the Pāli Canon and commentaries (Dean, 1998, p. 214; Library of Congress Online). Through the Pāli Text Society, she had edited or overseen many more publica-

[9] That year, at age 82, Rhys Davids stated that she made contact with her dead son in "Light- a Journal of Spiritualism," March, 1940 (Wilkes, 1999, pp. pp. 6, fn 6).

tions, virtually completing her and her husband's life's work (Stede, 1942, p. 267). Indeed, by the end of her long career, Rhys Davids had become a more prolific Pāli translator than her better-known husband (Walters J. S., p. 366 fn 22). Stede summarizes her groundbreaking contributions by saying, "the passing of Mrs. Rhys Davids closes the pioneer stage of Pāli studies" (ibid).

III. Influence as a Scholar

a. Buddhist Psychology and Ethics

Among her many contributions, Caroline Rhys Davids pioneered a use of language that still shapes how Westerners perceive Buddhism. In 1942, Stede summarized the impact of her work when he wrote, "It is not too much to say that the ideas of the educated layman about Pāli Buddhism to-day are those first put forth by Mrs. Rhys Davids" (Stede, 1942, p. 268). In 1968, Guy Welbon agreed that Stede's observation was still largely true, adding that the same "applies to Buddhists in South and Southeast Asia" (Welbon, 1968, p. 222). A full exploration of CAF Rhys Davids' lasting influence on Buddhists in the West and Asia has yet to be written.

Consider the use of a specific term, "Buddhist Psychology." Over the first twenty-two years of her career, Rhys Davids consistently championed Buddhist psychology, publishing at least half a dozen titles referencing some form of the words "Buddhist," "Psychology," and "Ethics." She published her first title linking the subjects in 1894[10]. Her subsequent translation of the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, the first book of the *Abhidhamma,* was entitled *A Buddhist manual of psychological ethics of the fourth century B.C*[11]. It is likely that her choice of words influenced Paul Carus, a publisher, pop-

[10] "The Vedalla Sutta, As Illustrating the Psychological Basis of Buddhist Ethics," *Hibbert Journal*, Apr., 1894, pp. 321-333, Cambridge University Press.

[11] The complete title of this translation is *A Buddhist manual of psychological ethics of the fourth century B.C.: being a translation, now made for the first time, from the original Pāḷi, of the first book in the Abhidhamma piṭaka, entitled Dhammasaṅgaṇī (compendium of states or phenomena).*

ular author, and key figure in American Buddhism (Tweed, 1992, pp. 46-47). One of his many books – *Nirvāṇa: a story of Buddhist psychology*, an English-language title that links Buddhism and psychology — was published in 1902. It now shares the digital shelves of Amazon.com with popular contemporary books on the same topics.

That same digital shelf contains Caroline Rhys Davids' *Buddhist Psychology,* a popular book released in 1914. *Buddhist Psychology* had a noticeable impact on the still-developing field of Western Psychology. It was cited and reviewed in a number of psychological journals of its day (Clark, 1916, pp 139-141; Riley, Jan 1916, pp. 1-4). Her work is still cited today by scholars and psychologists at the interstices of Buddhist Psychology, Western Psychology, and ethics[12].

Caroline Rhys Davids' penchant for titles incorporating psychological ethics has not gone unnoticed. Steven Collins quips that the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī* "has minced around the English-speaking world in Edwardian dress as 'Buddhist Psychological Ethics,' a typical piece of Mrs. Rhys Davidsian enthusiasm" (Collins, 2003, p. 687). However, her editorial commentaries between 1893 and 1917 reflect more than mere enthusiasm. For example, careful reading of her introduction to this volume reveals that Rhys Davids wove a Western interpretation of Buddhism based on comparative philosophy, psychology, and, as Collins suggests, an optimistic vision of human capacity (Rhys Davids, 1900, pp. xxxvii-xxxviii). Her rhetoric is carefully crafted, and she writes of incorporating logical arguments to engage "the skeptical and scientific reader – one of whom is better worth holding than a hundred over-credulous temperaments" (Rhys Davids, 1910, p. xxii).

To speak only of Caroline Rhys Davids' rhetorical approach to Buddhist psychology and ethics, however, is to ignore the depth of her investigation. Her translations and editorial treatments of the *Abhidhamma* were far from superficial Western appropriation or rationalist

[12] See Silva, Padmal. "Buddhist Psychology: A Review of Theory and Practice." *Current Psychology: Research & Reviews* 9.3 (1990): 236-254; and Virtbauer, Gerald. "The Western reception of Buddhism as a psychological and ethical system: developments, dialogues, and perspectives." *Mental Health, Religion & Culture* 15.3 (2012): 251-263.

gloss. Her nuanced rendering of some concepts in the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī* reflects a commitment to deeply comprehending the language and frameworks within the *Abhidhamma Piṭaka*. To that end, she often consulted Ledi Sayadaw, "the 'father' of the insight meditation tradition in Burma" (Bhikkhu Pesala, 2000, 2007). "Mrs. Rhys Davids was fondly called the 'London Devi' by the illustrious Ledi Sayadaw for her frequent references to him for expositions on knotty problems she had encountered in her translation of *Piṭaka* especially *Abhidhamma"* (Lay, 1998)[13]. Her questions were not limited to the minutia of mental processes, however. In one correspondence, for example, she asked, "If there is no permanent subject, how are memory and recognition possible?" (Rhinoceros Horn, 2012)[14]. Her question reflected long-standing interest; in the introduction to the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, she wrote "it is this psychologizing without a psyche that impressed me from the first" (Rhys Davids, 1900, p. xxiii).

To summarize, Caroline Rhys Davids deeply investigated the finer points of Buddhist psychology from an ethical, philosophically rational, perspective. In the process, she engaged in substantive dialogue on Buddhist psychology with Ledi Sayadaw and other monastic teachers. The approach to Buddhism as psychological ethics evident in her early work was not merely rationalist rhetorical strategy, or the naïve Western enthusiasm Collins apparently implies. Ledi Sayadaw clearly considered her deep learning investigation of Buddhism to be valid. Given the depth of her intellectual exploration and related dialogues with Ledi Sayadaw, it is no accident that Rhys Davids became the foremost Western expert on the *Abhidhamma* of her time. Unlike most of her contemporaries, she held that "the system of detailed mental analysis contained in the *Abhidhamma* was the basis of Buddhism" (Dean, 1998, p. 215). Her deep investigation privileged reason, psychology, and philosophy, which informed the scholarly framing of an entire *Piṭaka*. Her editorial choices influenced

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[13] The only letters I've seen directly are in *Manuals of Buddhism,* from the appendix of *The Manual of Cosmic Order*, which CAF Rhys Davids edited. The discussion is focused on subtle details of *Dhamma-niyama*, the "...order of arising and ceasing of all phenomena" (Ven. Maha Thera Ledi Sayadaw, 2004, p. 235).

[14] Volume XXXI of *The Journal of the Pāli Text Society* contains two letters from the Sayadaw to CAF Rhys Davids, excerpted in the blog referenced above. I've been unable to directly access the PTS Journal in question.

wider Western culture as well, promoting popular language linking Buddhism, psychology, and ethics.

b. From Esoterica to Philosophy: Reframing *Compendium*

Caroline Rhys Davids' framing of Buddhism from a philosophically rational perspective can also be clearly seen in her editorial contributions to *Compendium of States.* In 1910, She published one of two collaborative translations with Shwe Zan Aung, a Western-educated Burmese scholar, Buddhist practitioner, and monastic. The *Abhidhammattha Sangaha*, or *Compendium of Philosophy,* is an important commentary on the *Abhidhamma*, "a condensed theoretical work that complements the *Visuddhimagga"* (Wisdom Books, 2001 -2011)[15]. In the preface, CAF Rhys Davids states that she believes the *Compendium* to be the first published work of "Buddhist philosophy by East and West working hand-in-hand," and "trusts" it would inspire future collaborations (C. Rhys Davids 1910, xii)[16].

The project was truly collaborative: when Rhys Davids initially received the translated manuscript from Aung, she re-translated it from Pāli herself, sending both translations back to him for review and collation [17]. In the published volume, she credited Aung as *the* translator, publishing their respective perspectives in two separate introductions. In an act of scholarly transparency, she also included many of their negotiations about meaning verbatim in the appendix. She framed the inclusion of these debates as a contribution to future scholarship, writing in her introduction, "the comments and criticisms so generously poured out concerning my own efforts at translation... cannot but prove a valuable... contribution to Western inquiry in Buddhist philosophy" (Rhys Davids, 1910, p. xii).

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[15] The*Visuddhimagga,* an extensive commentary on the Pāli Canon, is considered a foundational text of *Theravāda* Buddhism.

[16] I first encountered this quote in an essay by Judith Snodgrass, "Defining Modern Buddhism: Mr. and Mrs. Rhys Davids and the Pali Text Society." *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa, and the Middle East, 27*(1), 186-202.

[17] The appendix to *Compendium* was compiled from nearly "three hundred folio pages of Aung's criticisms and her editorial responses" (Snodgrass,2007, p 196).

The negotiations highlighted different scholarly approaches. At that time, CAF Rhys Davids tended to "equate Pāli texts with early Buddhism" (Collett, 2006, p. 70). For her, rigorous methodology was necessary, and "meant strict adherence to the rules of academic philology and care for correct dating of texts" (Snodgrass, 2007, p. 196) and privileged logic, ethics, psychology, and "philosophy of mind" over depictions of meditative experience in the text (ibid). Some of her editorial and translation decisions drew objections from Aung, a practicing Buddhist, whose translations drew on personal experience of meditation and the doctrines of contemporary Burmese teachers (Snodgrass 2007, 196). Rhys Davids openly acknowledged the limitations of her rationalist perspective. She lamented that Westerners would not understand Buddhism until internalizing the perspective of those "nourished" on its "living and growing tradition of culture." She attributed this difficulty to the fact that she and other scholars "approach the subject wearing spectacles of our own Greek tradition," perceptively noting that this perspective is predicated "on permanence and identity, rather than change and transmitted force" (Rhys Davids, 1910, p. xii). In other words, Rhys Davids' editorial reframing of the *Compendium* was a self-aware, conscious process. She approached the book as a philosophical work and included within its pages a lively debate between two contemporary scholars.

Rhys Davids' editorial perspective had far-reaching consequences for future scholars and readers. Her English translation of the title alone, *Compendium of Philosophy,* "successfully positioned the book out of the exotica of Asian belief systems and into the mainstream of the Dewey system, [where it was] filed as philosophy" (Snodgrass, 2007, p. 196 fn 63). Positioning this commentary to the "Philosophy" section of the library may well have moved the minds of researchers and readers as well. The persuasive power of inherent context – here the context of the authoritative Dewey Decimal system of Western Library Science – should not be underestimated. I believe that in both categorization and content, the *Compendium* constitutes a partial systems-level reframing of *Abhidhamma*, and thus of Buddhism, from Asian esoterica to the respected dialogue of Western Philosophy.

c. Textual Methodology

As predicted in her obituary, Caroline Rhys Davids' work has continued to "prove an invaluable stimulus to further research" (Stede, 1942, p. 268). In her search for "Original Buddhism", CAF Rhys Davids began evaluating the relative age of fragments of text within the Pāli Canon. As early as 1877, TW Rhys Davids had mused that future scholarship of the texts may discover "whether they contain an older system hidden under a later one" (Welbon, 1968, p. 240). Caroline Rhys Davids began to attempt to uncover this older system around 1927 (Varma, 1971, p. 37), using her significant philological skill. She examined the historicity, or historical authenticity, of *teachings* in the Pāli Canon, and as her successor IB Horner wrote, "She was a pioneer in her way of tracing them" (Horner, 1942-43, p. 172). Rhys Davids' textual analysis ushered in the next phase of Buddhist studies. Hers were the first attempts "to ascertain the stratification of doctrines within the Pāli Canon" (Welbon, 1968, p. 240). Rhys Davids argued that early teachings of the Buddha did not deny an essential self, and that the Buddha was not antitheistic. Her iconoclastic claims went further, however[18]. According to IB Horner, CAF Rhys Davids used her textual methodology to support "a complete reinterpretation" of early Buddhism that Rhys Davids developed in the last twenty years of her life, which "fell intelligibly together into a coherent whole, profound, wise, and instinct with spiritual value" (1942-43 p 178).

Despite her broad knowledge of the Pāli Canon, Rhys Davids' more controversial claims were supported by relatively few, ambiguous, short text fragments (Winternitz 91 qtd p. 22). Her latter-career positions have since inspired intense scholarly debate. Welbon states that her belief "in what a religion ought to be" informed her conclusions about the original message of Buddhism. He also opined that her later work may have caused scholars to "have become increasingly critical of the use to which they put their tools of historical investigation" (p. 246).

[18] Her other hypotheses were, (a) will propelled man towards his highest potential, and(b) transmigrated an essential soul from lifetime to lifetime (Horner, 1942-43 p 178). Conflation of Buddhist rebirth with transmigration of the soul appeals to many Westerners, persisting today in popular culture (Hahn, 48, 2012).

Although her conclusions regarding Original Buddhism were controversial, her impact on scholars was groundbreaking. "The present generation of Buddhist scholars – those in India and Japan as well as in Europe and the United States – has learned much from Mrs. Rhys Davids" (Welbon, 1968, p. 246). Her scholarly influence is clear in *Studies in the Origins of Buddhism,* a classic of early Buddhist Studies. The book, by GC Pande, was acclaimed "as the best work on the subject in the previous 20 years" (Taani, 2011)[19]. In the first paragraph, Pande lauds Rhys Davids for pioneering a new approach, writing that her questions "rudely disturbed" existing Buddhist scholarship, stimulating "a more critical, a more historical outlook towards our texts... [which] necessitates a re-study of the problems of Buddhist origins" (2006, p. xiii). When comparing scholarly methodologies of historicity, he adds "Mrs. Rhys Davids' work is of paramount importance" (2006, p. 22)[20].

To put it concisely, Caroline Rhys Davids made sophisticated textual analysis "indispensable to the field of Buddhist studies" (Welbon, 1968, p. 246). As Pande's work suggests, her methods and the scholarly conversation they inspired may well have continued to provide the underpinnings for more sophisticated, contemporary, modes of analysis. Her controversial later hypotheses were clearly informed by her search for solace through Spiritualism after the death of her son. Nevertheless, her later work stimulated important dialogue about both her methodology and the critical use of analysis itself.

In conclusion, I submit that, above all, Caroline Rhys Davids was a skilled and prolific translator, a scholar to whom Western Buddhists and scholars are indebted. Her personal tragedy, poignant spiritual journey, and scholarly iconoclasm need not distract us from her impressive accomplishments. A pioneer of prodigious abilities, she offered subtle and nuanced English-language analysis of the most difficult Pāli literature. She framed early Buddhism as philosophy, and popularized, if not instantiated, conceptual links between Buddhist *Abhidhamma*, Western

[19] Taani quotes *The Journal of German Oriental Society*, 1961.
[20] Rhys Davids is cited eleven times in the first twenty-two pages of Pande's book.

psychology, and ethics. Her scholarly and popular influence lingers to this day.

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I B Horner – Some Biographical Notes

AMARO BHIKKHU (JCJ HORNER)

Anyone who has looked into the study of women in Buddhism has come across the book, "Women Under Primitive Buddhism,"[1] written by the British scholar I B Horner. In fact, we are indebted to her as the first scholar to study women's lives in the ancient Buddhist world. A former student of both the Rhys Davids, Horner was also a noted scholar responsible for translations of many Pāli texts, including the entire Vinaya Piṭaka (The Book of Discipline, six volumes); the Majjhima Nikāya (Middle Length Sayings, three volumes); and the Milinda Pañha (King Milinda's Questions).

As it turns out, I B Horner was a cousin of Ajahn Amaro, known by many as one of the founding abbots of Abhayagiri Buddhist Monastery in Redwood Valley, California. Ajahn Amaro is now abbot of Amaravati Buddhist Monastery in Great Gaddesden, north of London.

I asked Ajahn Amaro if he could share any family history about I B Horner for this journal, and he generously sent this biographical sketch. ~ Editor

Even though I B Horner is by far the most illustrious member of the Horner family to date, I did not even know of her existence before I had already become a Theravādan bhikkhu.

It was shortly after I had returned to England from Thailand, after having been in the monastery there for a couple of years, that my father casually remarked one day, "You must take after my cousin Bobby. I think she wrote a book about Buddhism." I was taken aback to hear this as, when I had seen 'I B Horner' on the spines of all the Vinaya books in the small Wat Pah Nanachat library, I had had the thought, "I wonder if this a family member... oh yes, very likely I'm sure..." I thus asked him,

[1] Horner, I.B., *Women Under Primitive Buddhism: Laywomen and Almswomen*. 1930 New York: Dutton and Company. 2011 Hawaii: Guttenberg Publishers.

"Is she called I B Horner?" "That's right," he replied, "her real name's Isaline Blew Horner, but we always called her Bobby."

In that first conversation, I found out that she had been born in 1896 and was thus considerably older than my father. He was born in 1913 and was perennially known by his generation of the family as 'Young Tom,' as he was last of his siblings and born six years after his nearest sister, Betty. As the only academic of the family, I B Horner had always been something of a lone wolf but she had, however, been quite close to his eldest sister Sylvia (always known as 'Jules'), who was born in 1900 and who also lived near IBH in St John's Wood, London, in her later years.

My father had been out of touch with IBH for many years, having last seen her, as I recall, at his brother Peter's funeral in about 1949. This was before my father had married and well before my siblings and I had appeared on the scene. At that time, my immediate family lived on a farm in Kent, and I recall as a small child various visits from my father's sisters, Auntie Jules (who fascinated me with her cigarette-rolling device) and Auntie Betty (his two brothers had both died), but never from IBH. She had little connection to her 'young' cousin and so we never saw or heard about her.

Once I knew of her existence, I wrote to her and let her know that Young Tom's son was a Theravādan bhikkhu, and how grateful I was for all of the translation work she had done over the years, particularly of the *Vinaya Piṭaka.* She replied with a polite letter but did not seem to be interested in having much closer contact. There was no, "What a marvelous coincidence! Please come and see me in London when you can." It was more along the lines of, "Thank you for letting me know. I hope that your life as a bhikkhu will be fulfilling"; and that was it. Unfortunately, I did not keep this letter, so I cannot quote it accurately.

I was not quite sure how to take this coolness of response but, as my father assured me that most of the Horner women tended to be somewhat gruff in manner, he encouraged me not to be put off, and that it was probably her way of expressing friendly appreciation.

As it happened, I did make contact again the following year and, somewhere in the summer or autumn of 1980, we arranged for me to make a visit to her home in St John's Wood, London. I was a young monk in those days, and the occasions when such junior members of the community needed to visit the capital were rare. I thus arranged with IBH to meet her when I could come up to town as an attendant for one of the monks who was teaching at the Hampstead group, as I recall. Sadly, I did not take the precaution of reminding her of the appointment a few days beforehand for, when we got to the door of her apartment at the appointed time, we were greeted by her maid/helper who told us that Miss Horner could not see us.

It was never said whether she was unwell or had simply forgotten that we were coming and was not up and dressed to greet us. We were only told that we could not be received by her at that time. So we took ourselves away and, despite an exchange of letters to arrange another time to meet, by the following April she had passed away.

Oddly enough, it was after her death and in meeting with the Sri Lankan monks of the London Buddhist Vihāra, as well as some of her other London friends, that I learned a great deal more about her. These were friends such as Irene Quittner, and Dorothy McPhie (an acupuncturist who later went to live in Brighton), and others of the Hampstead group.

From these conversations, this is what I can recall: Among these women friends she was known as 'Squizzie.' When I had the chance to meet with them and to chat about IBH, Dorothy chuckled as she recounted a comment made by IBH, shortly after I had made contact with her in 1980: "He is called 'Amaro' – what a *ridiculous* name!" Exactly why it was so ridiculous to her was not specified, but my guesses are that (a) the meaning of the word is 'Immortal,' so to call a mortal person that is oxymoronic; (b) the Thai convention for monks' names is to use the 'o' ending of the nominative case rather than the 'a' ending of the word-stem. The Sri Lankans and Burmese tend to snicker at this usage, as they consider it very irregular to bring Pāli case-endings, even when correct, into another language (it would be like our calling Ven. Sāriputta, "Ven. Sāri-

putto," or the Buddha, "the Buddho"), and I'm sure that IBH would have concurred with this.

One of the most interesting things I learned during those conversations concerned the first meeting of IBH with Prof. TW Rhys Davids. I was told that this encounter happened at a garden party in Cambridge, in about 1908. At that time, TWRD was resident in Manchester, being the professor of Comparative Religion at the university there; IBH was 11 or 12 years old. Why they both happened to be in Cambridge that day is unclear, but there seems to have been a large social event of some kind, and at this gathering the young girl and the 65-year-old academic happened to be seated next to each other at the lunch table.

Apparently, as they started to make polite conversation, an avid and engaging dialogue developed, and TWRD became very impressed with the quick-witted and forthright youngster. At a certain point, so taken with her interests and her obvious abilities, he made the now historic suggestion: "You know, young lady, when you grow up, you ought to study Pāli and Sanskrit." This conversation, under the summer skies of a garden in Cambridge, clearly made a deep impression on her for, when she finally returned to Cambridge as a student at Newnham College, this is exactly the course of study she pursued.

After her death, I also found out a little more about her life but from the Horner family side of things. Her father, Leonard Horner (b. 1861), and my grandfather, Charles Horner (b. 1863), were two of nine surviving children of a sprawling Victorian family. The family fortunes were based on a building company called Ashby & Horner. As I understand the story, when my great-grandfather, William Sims Horner, died, he left the ownership of the company to his eldest son, Herbert – nicknamed 'The Duke,' as he had always acted imperiously since childhood. The Duke had no heirs, and the only sibling whom he fully trusted was Leonard so, on his death, he left the company to him.

Leonard had two children, a son (William Frith Horner, who was killed in an airship accident in WWI) and IBH. As he had no great love for the building trade, Leonard sold off the company and, when he died, all of the proceeds from that sale were bequeathed to IBH and her mother,

Annie. As I understand it, the largest part of the funding for the Pāli Text Society over these last many decades has come from this legacy received by IBH.

Despite the large number of Horner siblings in my grandfather's generation, of the four brothers and five sisters who survived into adulthood, several of them never married or had no children. This resulted in the strange circumstance that, by the time my father and mother married, he and IBH were the only ones still carrying the family name.

My father was not a particularly mercenary type but he had been poor all his life, so, when IBH passed away in 1981, he had the hope that: "We are the last of the Horners, so perhaps she'll leave the remainder of the family fortune to us." When the contents of her will were communicated to him, he discovered that she had left him all the family heirlooms – the 17th Century family bible, a silver salver with the family tree engraved upon it, several pieces of 17th & 18th Century furniture – but NO cash... All the money went to the PTS.

Personally, I thought this fair enough; she had given most of her adult life to the study of the Pāli language and especially to the work of the PTS, and she knew full well that, without such backing, the PTS would fold up very rapidly. It does not sell enough books to survive as a commercial institution.

He, however was not pleased at her choice, and I failed to endear myself to him by the somewhat flippant observation that, since I was a bhikkhu and thus an ongoing recipient of the fruits of the PTS, in a way the money was still in the family. Papa was not amused. Still, he got over it, and the heirlooms are now being carefully looked after by my sisters.

Incidentally, since I changed my name legally to Amaro Bhikkhu in 1981, and since my younger sister Jane was married in 1994 and became Jane Hill, our elder sister Kate Horner is the last one of that once huge family still using the name.

One last item concerning her death is also worth mentioning. She was very highly respected by the Sri Lankan monks of the London Buddhist Vihāra, and particularly by the abbot, Ven. Dr. Saddhātissa –

also a noted Pāli scholar. When she died, they came to chant with the body and to perform blessing ceremonies for her.

She died on Saturday April the 25th but, owing to the marriage at Marylebone Register Office on April 27th of Ringo Starr and Barbara Bach, the place was in an uproar, so it wasn't until Tuesday the 28th that her death could be registered and her body taken care of. The monks from the London Buddhist Vihāra thus went to her apartment every day and carried out the various ceremonies and blessings for her.

I have a vivid memory of being at her funeral, I believe on May the 2nd, and one of the Sri Lankan monks telling me: "We went every day, for so many days, but her body did not decay at all. And another thing: her eyes were open and they completely changed in color over that time; eventually they were perfectly blue!" He was very impressed and took these signs to be indications of the vast merit she had developed through the gift of her Buddhist scholarship to the world and the generous support of Buddha-Dhamma throughout her life.

This is about all I can bring to mind about IBH at present. The genealogical records that my sister Jane has managed to put together might yield a few more snippets, but I do not yet have copies of those here at Amaravati. I hope these few notes will be of interest.

Beautiful Eyes Seen with Insight as Bereft of Beauty – Subhā Therī and Her Male Counterpart in the Ekottarika-āgama

BHIKKHU ANĀLAYO

With the present paper I follow up a theme broached by Olivia (2011: 14) in the previous issue of the present journal regarding ways of reading the *Therīgāthā*. She observes that "we are indeed fortunate that any texts composed by ancient women have been preserved. However, we should not let our gratitude for these female voices lead us into projecting our values anachronistically and observing only their 'femaleness'". Instead, she notes that "it is necessary to read the *Therīgāthā* within its specific cultural and historical contexts. Not doing so does an injustice to the poems of these female disciples".

Regarding Buddhist Studies in general, Faure (2003: 5f) observes that at times "feminist scholars tend to project current normative conceptions and ideologies onto past cultures ... much feminist work on Buddhism has been concerned with 'singing the praises of exceptional women' or chronicling the indignities suffered by women. This approach, however, is increasingly criticized as being blind to cultural and historical contexts."

Since the groundbreaking translation and study by Rhys Davids (1909/1964) and Horner (1930/1990: 162–210), considerable scholarly attention has been dedicated to the *Therīgāthā*.[1] Due to the efforts of these scholars we have become aware of many facets of this collection,

* I am indebted to Rod Bucknell, Alice Collett and Shi Kongmu for comments on a draft version of the present paper.

[1] Besides translations provided by Norman 1971/1989, Murcott 1991 and Pruitt 1998/1999, studies of aspects or the whole of the collection have been undertaken by, e.g., Lienhard 1975, Gokhale 1976, Lang 1986, Dublay 1988, Jootla 1988, Kloppenborg 1995, Rajapakse 1995, Blackstone 1998/2000 and Choubey 2009, to name just a few.

and I believe that Olivia has a point that the *Therīgāthā* is sometimes read from a slightly one-sided perspective that over-emphasizes gender-related issues, thereby running the risk of ignoring the doctrinal points the stanzas intend to convey. With this I certainly do not intend to downplay the central importance of the *Therīgāthā* as a remarkable record of female spirituality in the early Buddhist tradition. My point is only that there is often more to its stanzas than the topic of gender.

To illustrate this point, in what follows I take up the motif of gouging out one's eyes as a way of demonstrating their lack of inherent beauty. The idea of taking out an eye is to some degree a natural one, given that the eye is the only physical organ that can be disjoined from the body without recourse to a surgical instrument. Moreover, once taken out of its socket an eye indeed loses all of its former attraction. In the *Therīgāthā* this motif occurs in a set of stanzas attributed to the nun Subhā, which report that she took out one of her eyes in order to keep a sexually aroused man at bay. After presenting the main plot, I then survey comments made by some scholars regarding this tale, followed by presenting a discourse in a collection preserved in Chinese translation which contains a similar motif, but where the gouging out of an eye is undertaken by a male protagonist rather than a female one.

The stanzas of the *Therīgāthā* attributed to Subhā Jīvakambavanikā begin by describing that, while on her way to Jīvaka's Mango Grove, she is intercepted by a man with evil intentions (Thī 366). She asks why he is obstructing her, indicating to him that it is not proper for him to touch a woman who has gone forth, adding that she is one who has gone beyond sensual desire. The man replies by praising her beauty, telling her that she should give up her robes. He tells her that instead of going alone into the woods, she could dress up beautifully and live in luxury with him. On being asked what particularly attracts him, he praises her beautiful eyes, explaining that looking at her eyes arouses his sensual desire ever more (Thī 381f). Subhā replies by declaring her total disinterest in sensuality and pointing out that an eye is simply a little ball set in a hollow place. She then plucks out one of her eyes and hands it to the man (Thī 396). He is shocked by this act and comes to his senses, begging her forgiveness for his foolish behavior. The stanzas conclude by

reporting that later, after having seen the Buddha, Subhā's eye is miraculously restored (Thī 399).

In his study of the *Therīgāthā*, Rajapakse (1995: 16f) makes the important observation that Subhā's stanzas are a striking example for a tendency in the *Therīgāthā* to depict "a veritable role-reversal: far from fostering passion, in its verses women proclaim piety and dispassion to worldly and passionate *men*". He concludes that with the stanzas spoken by Subhā "it is women's success in overcoming ... *men*, and their considered attempts to divert women from spiritual endeavours, that the verses ... most strikingly record".

In a detailed analysis of the stanzas attributed to the man who accosts Subhā, Kloppenborg (1995: 160) points out that these reflect "the traditional arguments of male chauvinism", namely that

- "a young, beautiful women should not be celibate",
- "a woman should not be alone and needs male protection",
- "a woman is a man's playmate",
- "a woman under male control is happy",
- "if a woman decides to remain alone, she is despicable".

In this way, the Subhā tale can be seen to caricature such male presumptions – needless to say, such presumptions are not confined to an ancient Indian setting – set against the vivid contrast of a woman who has reached the acme of spiritual perfection and gone beyond any interest in what male company might have to offer.

In a paper dedicated entirely to the Subhā tale, Trainor (1993: 65) draws attention to the eyes as "the central metaphor of the poem, with its complex associations of aesthetic beauty and spiritual insight". The primary contrast in the stanzas indeed revolves around a male 'blinded' by passion in contrast to the nun's 'insight'. By offering her eye to the man, Subhā in a way bestows on him at least an inkling of her 'vision' of the true nature of the human body. The same theme continues until the

happy end of the story, as on coming to 'see' the Buddha her 'eye' is miraculously restored.

Based on a detailed study of the Subhā tale as part of her investigation into instances of misogyny in Buddhist texts, Wilson (1996: 169) comments that "there is great irony in the fact that Subhā must blind herself in order to get the attention of the rogue and make him listen to her. It is only by blinding herself, it seems, that Subhā is at last treated as a woman of insight – a seer and not just a sight to be seen. Perhaps we can also read Subhā's willingness to give up her own organs of sight as an indication that she eschews the female gaze".

Wilson (1996: 179) then concludes her study of several such cases by indicating that "self-disfiguring nuns like Subhā who edify men through heroic displays of their bodily repulsiveness ... thereby repudiate their role as agents of Māra. In so doing, these potential minions of Māra show themselves to be dutiful servants of their male counterparts within the *sangha*".

In her study, Wilson (1996: 169) also provides a translation of the Subhā *Therīgāthā*, the last stanza of which indicates that "when she [Subhā] saw the one with the marks of perfect merit [the Buddha], her eye was restored to its former condition". The formulation in this stanza (Thī 399) makes it clear that, contrary to what Wilson states earlier, Subhā had not 'blinded' herself. Subhā had gouged out one eye, but the other eye was still intact, since it was on "seeing" the Buddha with this eye that the other eye she had earlier taken out was restored. Wilson appears to have overlooked this part, as she speaks of Subhā "blinding" herself and then also of Subhā's giving up "her own organs of sight", where the plural does not match the single eye taken out according to the actual stanza.

Furthermore, I am also not convinced by Wilson's view of Subhā as a potential minion of Māra, a role the nun then supposedly repudiates. Since throughout Subhā's stanzas there is no explicit reference to Māra, if Māra is to be brought in, we need to turn to similar episodes where a male acts as a sexual aggressor in regard to a nun. Such episodes can be found in the *Bhikkhunī-saṃyutta* (and its Chinese parallels), where several

discourses report how nuns are challenged by Māra, inviting them to enjoy sensuality, implying a sexual threat similar in kind to the present case (Anālayo 2014). Based on the parallelism to the Subhā incident, the one who could be identified with Māra in the Subhā *Therīgāthā* is clearly the impassioned male, not the detached nun. Thus, as far as I can see, Subhā is not a minion of Māra in the first place and thus has no need to repudiate such a role.

I also have difficulties in understanding why Subhā's action provides a dutiful service to Buddhist monks, as suggested by Wilson. Similar to the case of Māra, throughout Subhā's stanzas there is no reference to monks at all. It also seems safe to assume that monks would not constitute the target audience of the *Therīgāthā*. The relative dearth of discourses spoken by nuns in the canonical collections in general and also the circumstance that counterparts to the *Therīgāthā* have not been preserved by other Buddhist schools clearly point to the predilection of the male monastic reciters, who apparently had little interest in teachings given by nuns. Thus I find no real basis for interpreting the action undertaken by Subhā as in some way providing a service to Buddhist monks.

Instead of a minion of Māra who blinds herself as a service to monks, I would see the main point of this story to be simply about contrasting the attraction of physical beauty with the Buddhist doctrinal view about the true nature of the body. In support of my interpretation of the significance of the gouging out of the eye when confronted with someone who is full of passion, I would like to turn to a tale found in the *Ekottarika-āgama* collection preserved in Chinese translation. This tale reports a similar situation, with the notable difference that the main protagonist is a male. That is, here a male gouges out an eye when confronted with an impassioned woman.

The *Ekottarika-āgama* as a whole is a collection of discourses that remained open to later additions for a longer time compared to both the Pāli *Nikāya*s and the other *Āgama*s preserved in Chinese translation (Anālayo 2009). Thus one regularly finds stories in *Ekottarika-āgama* discourses that in the Pāli canon only have counterparts in the commentaries.

According to modern scholarship, some degree of lateness is also evident in both the *Theragāthā* and the *Therīgāthā* collections.[2] This much can in fact be seen in the last of the stanzas related to Subhā, which reports her magical recovery of the one eye she has earlier taken out of its socket. While in the early discourses the Buddha is often compared to a doctor, this is usually meant only symbolically. The idea that seeing him miraculously brings about an actual healing of the body is something found mainly in literature belonging to the later, commentarial period. Hence Horner (1930/1990: 339) is probably correct when she comments that the magical healing of Subhā's eyes is "a legendary accretion obviously inserted later".

Thus the tale of Subhā and the tale in the *Ekottarika-āgama* could have come into being at more or less the same period and there is no *a priori* reason for us to assume that the relevant stanzas in the *Therīgāthā* must be earlier than the discourse from the *Ekottarika-āgama*,[3] to which I now turn.

[2] Norman 1983a: 74 points out that the *Theragāthā* has various metres, ranging from very early to later metres, besides which there are "also references to beliefs and practices of the type which ... point to lateness". He concludes that, while incorporating early material, the collection as a whole took probably about three centuries to come into being, followed by indicating (page 77) that the same applies to the *Therīgāthā*. In a similar vein, von Hinüber 1996/1997: 53 explains that "probably both collections have been growing over a long period, slowly absorbing verses commemorating monks or nuns living at quite different times, for although the commentary states that Ānanda recited these collections at the first council ... other verses are supposed to be much younger even by the tradition and as having been added on the occasion of the second council ... or still later at the time of the third council under Aśoka".

[3] This has been suggested by Greene 2006: 51 note 136, who discusses this tale and also translates a few excerpts.

Translation

I heard it like this.[4] At one time the Buddha was staying in the Deer Park at Benares together with a great company of five hundred monks. At that time the Blessed One told the monks: "You should give attention to the perception of impermanence and make much of the perception of impermanence. By giving attention to the perception of impermanence and making much of the perception of impermanence, you will eradicate craving for sensuality, craving for form and craving for the formless, and you will completely eradicate conceit and ignorance. Why is that?

"In the distant past, a long time ago, there was a solitary Buddha named Beautiful Eyes. His facial appearance was very handsome,[5] with a complexion like a peach blossom, he was of dignified appearance, his mouth exuded the fragrance of lotus flowers and his body exuded the fragrance of sandalwood.

"At that time the solitary Buddha Beautiful Eyes, when the time had come to go begging alms, put on his outer robes and took his bowl to enter the city of Benares. Gradually proceeding he approached the house of an eminent householder and stood in silence outside the gate.

"At that time the householder's daughter saw from afar that there was a practitioner of the path standing outside the gate[6]. He was incomparably handsome, with a very special facial appearance, rarely found in the world. His mouth exuded the fragrance of lotus flowers and his body exuded the fragrance of sandalwood.

"Her mind was aroused with sensual desire. She approached that monk and said: 'Now, you are handsome, with a complexion like a peach blossom, rarely found in the world. Now, I am a virgin and I am also handsome. Let us be together. In my home there are many treasures and immeasurable wealth. Being a recluse is not at all easy.'

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[4] The translated text is EĀ 38.9 at T II 724a7 to b27.
[5] My translation follows a variant reading.
[6] My rendering as "householder's daugher" follows an indication by Hirakawa 1997: 1195 regarding the Sanskrit equivalent to the Chinese characters found in the present instance.

"Then the solitary Buddha said: 'Dear sister, now what part [of me] do you feel lustfully attached to?' The householder's daughter said: 'Right now I am attached to the color of your eyes, also to the fragrance of lotus flowers exuding from your mouth and the fragrance of sandalwood exuding from your body.'

"Then the solitary Buddha held out his left hand and with the right hand plucked out an eye and placed it in the middle of his palm. He said to her: 'The eye you crave – here it is. Dear sister, what part [of me] are you attached to now? Just like a boil, which has nothing desirable to it, so this eye oozes impurities. Dear sister, you should know that the eye is like foam, being unstable, deceptive and false, deceiving people in the world.

"The ear,[7] the nose, the mouth, the body and the mind are all unstable, deceptive and false. The mouth is a container for spittle; what comes out of it is impure matter; what it contains, [the teeth], is just white bones. The body is a container of pain, its nature is to become worn away. It is a place constantly full of foul smells and troubled by worms, being like a painted jar full of impurities inside. Dear sister, what part [of me] are you attached to now?

"Therefore, dear sister, apply your mind and give attention to these phenomena as deceptive and false. If, sister, you give attention to the eye and forms as impermanent, then whatever perception you have of attachment and desire will naturally disappear. The ear, nose, mouth, body and mind are all impermanent. Having given attention to this, whatever desire there is in the mind will naturally disappear. [If] you give attention to the six sense organs [like this], there will be no more perceptions of sensuality.'

"Then the householder's daughter felt embarrassed and stepped forward to pay respect at the feet of the solitary Buddha. She said to the solitary Buddha: 'From now on I am going to correct [myself]. I will cultivate what is wholesome, without giving rise to further perceptions of sensuality. Please accept my regret for my transgression.' Three times she spoke like this.

"The solitary Buddha said: 'Wait, wait, dear sister, this is not your fault. It is because of my offences done in the past that I have received this body. On seeing it, people arouse sentiments of sensuality.

"One should carefully contemplate the eye: 'This eye is not me, nor does it belong to another;[8] it is not made by me, nor is it made by another. It has arisen from nowhere and, having come into existence, it will naturally decay and be destroyed. Whether in the past, in the present or in future, all this is caused by the coming together of conditions.

"The meaning of the coming together of conditions is: 'In dependence on this, that exists; with the arising of this, that arises. This not being, that is not, with the cessation of this, that ceases.' The eye, the ear, the nose, the mouth, the body and the mind are just like that; they are all completely empty.

"Therefore, dear sister, do not attach with the eye to forms. By not attaching to forms you will attain the place of peace, without further sentiments of sensual desire. You should train yourself like this, dear sister.' Then the solitary Buddha, having given that woman a teaching on the fourfold impermanence, rose up into the air, manifested the eighteen transformations and returned to his dwelling place.

"Then that woman contemplated the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body and mind, understanding that there is nothing to them. In a tranquil place she gave attention to this teaching. That woman also gave attention to the fact that the six senses are without an owner. She attained the fourfold even-mindedness (*brahmavihāra*) and on the breaking up of the body, after death, was reborn in the Brahmā world.

"Monks you should know that if you give attention to the perception of impermanence and make much of the perception of impermanence, you will completely eradicate craving for sensuality, for forms and for the formless, and you will get rid of all conceit and ignorance. Therefore, monks, you should train like this."

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[7] My translation follows a variant reading.
[8] My translation follows a variant reading.

At that time the monks, hearing what the Buddha had said, were delighted and received it respectfully.

Study

The doctrinal significance of the gouging out of the eye is self-evident in the above tale from the *Ekottarika-āgama*, since the whole story comes as an explanation of the initial instruction given by the Buddha that perception of impermanence will lead to freedom from all types of craving. That is, the theme of going beyond craving is the central topic. The same can safely be assumed to apply to the Subhā tale as well.

Unlike the Subhā episode, however, the exchange that leads up to the act of gouging out the eye in the present tale is rather brief, lacking the dramatic build up and the tension created by the apprehension that the other might eventually use force to achieve his aim. In the above tale, the solitary Buddha is obviously not under any kind of physical threat, hence the scene is naturally less dramatic.

In Buddhist thought, a solitary Buddha (*Paccekabuddha*) differs from a full-fledged Buddha by not having a following of disciples.[9] Nevertheless, a solitary Buddha does at times dispense short teachings, as seen in the present case. Such a teaching regularly tends to contain a strong visual component, as solitary Buddhas often teach through their appearance or through magical feats (cf. Wiltshire 1990: 66f and 76ff). Thus for the solitary Buddha in the present tale to gouge out an eye is in line with this tendency of teaching through some form of action. The same can be seen in the miracles he performs when he is about to depart. In Buddhist literature in general, the teachings delivered by a solitary Buddha arouse inspiration in the listener and lead to rebirth in a higher heavenly realm, while teachings that result in the listener's awakening are usually rather the domain of a full-fledged Buddha.

[9] On my reasons for adopting the expression "solitary Buddha", contrary to suggestions by Norman 1983b, cf. Anālayo 2010: 11ff.

As already noted above, unlike the Subhā episode, the present motif of gouging out the eye recurs with a significant shift of gender in the protagonist, as the disfiguration is undertaken by a male. Moreover, even the solitary Buddha's attractiveness is not depicted in terms that emphasize maleness. The text introduces him as handsome with a face is like a peach blossom, a comparison with flowers that one would have rather expected to find in a description of a beautiful woman. Moreover, the fragrance of lotus flowers that exudes from his mouth and the scent of sandalwood from his body both highlight more feminine descriptions of beauty. In another discourse in the *Ekottarika-āgama* the same type of description is associated with the queen of a wheel-turning king, as part of a depiction of what, according to ancient Indian standards, apparently constitutes the acme of female beauty and attractiveness.[10]

Also noteworthy is how the solitary Buddha tells the woman to stop worrying about what she had done, clarifying that from his perspective it is his own fault to have such an attractive body. The fact that the speaker of these words is a male makes it clear that these words need not be interpreted as a form of self-reproach for being attractive – a natural interpretation had the speaker been a female – but may simply be meant as a kind remark in order to dispel the embarrassment and regret felt by the householder's daughter.[11]

Clearly, the present tale inverts simplistic gender roles, thereby offering a significant corrective to readings of the Subhā tale from a perspective that is only concerned with the issue of gender discrimination. Once the gouging out of an eye by Subhā is considered in conjunction with the same act undertaken by the solitary Buddha, it becomes clear that this is simply a teaching aimed at deconstructing the notion of beauty of any body, male or female.

Detachment from craving in regard to the body is in fact a requirement in the early Buddhist soteriological scheme, the relevance of

[10] EĀ 50.4 at T II 807c15; for a translation of this discourse cf. Anālayo 2011.

[11] The present case thus stands in contrast to what Faure 1998: 20 sees as a pattern in Buddhist texts, where "in a man, beauty is often perceived as the effect of good karma, whereas in a woman it is usually seen as the result of past sin – paradoxically enough, because it produces attachment in men".

which is independent of the gender of the practitioner. This can be seen in the instructions given in the *Satipaṭṭhāna-sutta* and its parallels on contemplating the anatomical nature of the body, which are clearly meant to be applied first of all to one's own body. The Pāli version introduces the listing of anatomical parts with the phrase "there are in this body", a phrase similarly found in the two Chinese parallel versions, one of which explicitly speaks of this body "of mine".[12] That is, a male will first of all have to contemplate his own body, just as a female will first of all have to contemplate her own body. It is only when such contemplation has been successfully cultivated that the same understanding will also be applied to the bodies of others.

Due to the circumstance that the Buddha apparently traveled together with monks, it is only natural that the discourses often address a male monastic audience, with the inevitable result that the dangers of the attraction of female bodies are a frequent topic. Neither the frequency of such instructions nor the tale of Subhā, however, implies that early Buddhist texts adopt a simplistic logic where one gender is cast unilaterally in the role of being the tempter and the other of being the victim.

Primary Sources

EĀ *Ekottarika-āgama*

MĀ *Madhyama-āgama*

MN *Majjhima-nikāya*

T Taishō edition (CBETA)

Thī *Therīgāthā* (PTS edition)

[12] MĀ 98 at T I 583b6 indicates that the contemplation is to be undertaken "within this body of mine", something implicit in the corresponding reference to what is "in this body" in MN 10 at MN I 57,15 and EĀ 12.1 at T II 568a19.

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The Mother of All Dhammas: The Appropriation of a Feminist Symbol in Theravāda Thought and Practice

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With the interdisciplinary field of women's studies well established, there is now a wealth of feminist and gynocentric readings of Buddhist traditions. In the case of *Theravāda* in particular, the goal of reinstating the nuns' lineage has also motivated the rise of such readings. Yet Buddhist feminist and Buddhological gynocentric works have typically found *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna* literary traditions more productive than *Theravāda* sources for attempts at feminist revalorization of Buddhism.[1]

In her article "Gendered Symbols in *Theravāda* Buddhism: Missed Positives in the Representation of the Female," Kate Crosby argues that this situation is the result of an imbalance in the chronological spectrum of literary sources used, with feminist examinations of *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna* drawing on texts from across the centuries, while most feminist studies of *Theravāda* confine themselves to a relatively narrow selection of canonical texts. By drawing on a wider range of *Theravāda* literary sources—spanning from the earliest, to the "medieval," and to the premodern periods of the tradition—Crosby shows that *Theravāda* soteriology and cosmography employ multiple positive feminine symbols, thus challenging the portrayal of *Theravāda* literature as more suppressive of women than *Mahāyāna* literature.[2]

One such positive feminine symbol that Crosby mentions, albeit only briefly, upon examining the "medieval" *Abhidharma* (Sanskrit)/*Abhidhamma* (Pāli) tradition, is the *mātikā.* The term *mātikā* derives from the Sanskrit word "mother" and denotes the doctrinal lists of

[1] In feminist theology, the task of "revalorization" involves working with the categories and concepts of a traditional religion in the light of feminist values.
[2] Crosby 2000: 141-98.

dharmas (Sanskrit)/*dhammas* (Pāli) which form the basis for the *Abhidhamma* analyses of the world as experienced and as taught by the Buddha. It merits, however, further investigation, for it has multiple meanings and the use of doctrinal lists, if not the use of the term *mātikā* itself, dates to the very beginning of Buddhist literature.

In this paper, I shall explore the *mātikā* as a feminine symbol in *Theravāda* thought and practice. Expanding upon Crosby's observation, I shall first explain the meaning and role of the *mātikā* in both the *Nikāyas* and *Abhidhamma* literature. I shall then examine the significance of the *mātikā* as serving the purpose of Buddhist meditation, particularly mindfulness practice. Finally, I shall discuss the *mātikā* within the context of "esoteric" or "tantric" *Theravāda*, a relatively little known tradition of *Theravāda* texts and practices now found primarily in mainland Southeast Asia. This tradition further supports the claim that positive feminine symbols are present in *Theravāda* literature as they are in *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna*, and challenges the widespread portrayal of *Theravāda* as a rather uniform Buddhist tradition.

I. The *mātikā* in the *Nikāyas*

A conspicuous characteristic of Buddhist literature is its abundance of lists. It seems that Buddhism has a list for just about everything: the Triple Gem/ three "refuges" and three characteristics of conditioned phenomena; the four noble truths, four foundations of mindfulness, four meditations (*jhānas*), and four "divine abidings"; the five aggregates (*khandhas*), five hindrances, and five precepts; the six sense spheres; the seven factors of awakening; the noble eightfold path; the ten fetters; the twelve links of dependent co-arising and twelve sense spheres; the eighteen elements of perception; and many others.

It is difficult to say how many lists there are exactly in the four primary *Nikāya*s. What is clear is that much of the canonical sutta material preserved in the *Nikāya*s is built around classification lists of doctrinal topics that constitute condensed shorthand accounts of the Buddha's

Dhamma.[3] The number and variety of lists tended to increase as time went on, but lists make up a very old feature of Buddhist literature.[4]

The *Nikāya* lists are organized according to either topical or numerical criteria. Topically, the items enumerated are divided into different types based on some doctrinal principle. Lists of this kind abound in the *Saṃyutta-nikāya*. Numerically, the lists catalogue groups of identical number of items, or groups of items that sequentially increase in their number, commencing with one or two items and proceeding to higher numbers. This method is employed, for example, in the *Saṅgīti-* and *Dasuttara-suttas,* as well as in the *Aṅguttara-nikāya*.[5]

That lists are such an integral part of Buddhist literature is surely related with its being an oral literature, namely, a body of texts that for a long period were composed and transmitted orally and only subsequently became fixed in the form of written scriptures. Theories of the oral composition and transmission of early Buddhist literature fall into two categories. On the one hand, some scholars have emphasized the role of improvisation, arguing that the early Buddhist literature was changed and adapted according to the particular conditions of performance and recitation.[6] Against this theory, others have argued for a relatively fixed oral composition and transmission of Buddhist literature, where verbatim accuracy would have been the norm.[7]

These differences notwithstanding, mnemonic lists of doctrinal topics would have been useful for both methods of oral composition and transmission. According to the improvisational method, as Rupert Gethin suggests, the lists "act as a kind of flowchart for the composition of a discourse," providing a form or structure within which one can

[3] When capitalized, the word Dhamma is used here in the sense of the Buddha's teaching(s), in distinction from the plural *dhammas,* which appears later in this section in the sense of "states of mind." I discuss further the plural *dhammas* in Section II.
[4] Gethin 2001: 13.
[5] Gethin 1992: 153–7; Buswell & Jaini 1996: 83–9.
[6] Proponents of this theory include L.S. Cousins (1983) and Rupert Gethin (1992).
[7] Supporters of this view include Richard Gombrich (1990: 21), K.R. Norman (1997: 49), and Alexander Wynne (2004: 108ff).

improvise as appropriate.[8] Under the view of a relatively fixed oral composition and transmission, the lists facilitate memorization, thus supporting the accurate reproduction of the content at each recitation.

The Pāli term that denotes these classification lists, or, more literally, matrices, is *mātikā,* though it was not employed in Buddhist literature until the end of the *Nikāya* period, around the third century BCE. Translators of Buddhist texts often render the word as "summary," as it is predominantly used in the Pāli commentaries, where *mātikā* means any ordered list or table of items summarizing the Dhamma and suggesting further explication of fundamental doctrinal topics.[9] Albeit there is nothing incorrect about this rendering of the term *mātikā,* it falls short of conveying the unique ways in which Buddhist literature forms itself around lists.

Rather, a set of other meanings of the Sanskrit equivalent *mātṛkā* informs this unique dynamics of lists in Buddhist literature and practice, which goes far beyond a mere tedious characteristic of an oral tradition.

The Sanskrit word *mātṛkā* is a derivative of the word *mātṛ,* which is the ordinary term for "mother." *Mātṛkā*, too, means "mother" or "grandmother," and is also used figuratively to mean "source", "seed," or "origin."[10] In his article "The *Mātikā:* Memorization, Mindfulness, and the List," Gethin argues that it is precisely this underlying figurative meaning of "mother" that animates the workings of Buddhist lists. He demonstrates this claim by considering the proliferation of lists in Buddhist literature, from the *Nikāyas* through the texts of the *Abhidhamma* tradition.

In this section, my concern is with the dynamics of the *mātikā* in the *Nikāyas* only. An obvious starting point for examining this topic in juxtaposition to both Buddhist doctrine and practice is the list of the

[8] Gethin 1992: 156.
[9] *Pali English Dictionary,* s.v. *mātikā*. Throughout this paper, I shall use the singular and plural forms *mātikā/s* interchangeably to refer to the Buddhist "lists."
[10] *A Sanskrit-English Dictionary,* s.v. *mātṛkā*.

noble eightfold path. The following summary of the *Nikāya* treatment of the list of the noble eightfold path is informed by Gethin's analysis.[11]

Granted, the list of the noble eightfold path is closely related with the equally fundamental list of the four noble truths, for it is presented as a succinct compendium of the fourth noble truth, namely, the truth about the path leading to the cessation of suffering.[12] Throughout the *Nikāya*s, the eight factors of the path are itemized as a bare list on dozens of occasions, altogether occurring hundreds of times.[13] The bare statement of this list is:

> Just this is the noble eightfold path, namely, right view, right thought, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.[14]

It is apparent from the texts that this bare list is a linchpin of doctrinal topics discussed in various contexts throughout the *Nikāya*s. Thus, the eight factors function as a seed that generates fundamental Buddhist lists.

The first factor, **right view** (*sammā-diṭṭhi*) is explained as knowledge of suffering, its arising, its cessation, and the path leading to its cessation. This is but knowledge of the four noble truths, which the list of the noble eightfold path is intended to explicate. We see here an interesting dynamics, whereby a list turns back on itself, arriving back where we started.

The second factor, **right thought** (*sammā-saṅkappa*) is divided into three kinds of thought: thought free from desire, free from hatred, and free from cruelty. The third factor, **right speech** (*sammā-vācā*) is of four kinds, namely, refraining from wrong speech, from divisive speech, from hurtful speech, and from idle chatter. The fourth factor,

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[11] 1992: 151-3.

[12] See, for instance, S V 421-22.

[13] In his book *The Buddhist Path to Awakening*, Gethin counts 64 occasions in the four Nikāyas on which the factors of the path are itemized, which make up 372 "times" they are listed (this includes one *Vinaya* context (Vin I 10)). See Gethin 2001: 163-4.

[14] E.g., D I 157, 165; II 251, 311; M I 15-16, 48-55; S II 42-3, V 8-10; A I 177, 180, 217.

right action (*sammā-kammanta*), is of three kinds, that is, refraining from attacking living beings, from taking what is not given, and from non-celibacy. Note that the items under right thought, speech, and action constitute the core of the Buddhist account of morality or conduct (*sīla*). In fact, the seven items under right speech and action comprise four of the five precepts.[15]

The fifth factor, **right livelihood** (*sammā-ājīva*), seems to be far more generic: it is simply explained as "abandoning wrong livelihood and making a living by means of right livelihood." The seemingly tautological definition of this factor makes more sense if we take into account the way of life of the monk living on alms and devoted to the spiritual life, whose conduct equals livelihood. For such one, as Gethin points out, "all acts of speech and body tend to become livelihood, for the spiritual life itself is his 'livelihood.'"[16]

Next down the bare list of the eight factors, **right effort** (*sammā-vāyāma*) is explained by way of the stock formula of the four endeavors (*sammappadhāna*): namely, endeavors for the sake of non-arising of unskillful states of mind (*dhammas*) that have not arisen, for the abandoning of unskillful states of mind that have arisen, for the sake of the arising of skillful states of mind that have not arisen, and for the establishing or cultivation of skillful states of mind that have arisen.

The seventh factor, **right mindfulness** (*sammā-sati*), is explained by another stock formula detailing four kinds of contemplation known as the four foundations of mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhānā*). These four, as described in the *Satipaṭṭhāna-sutta* and the *Mahāsatipaṭṭhāna-sutta,* lead to yet additional lists of doctrinal topics with which they are closely associated.[17] Most notably, the practice of the fourth foundation of mindfulness, "the contemplation of Dhamma with regards to *dhammas,*" involves the contemplation of a series of Buddhist fundamentals: the

[15] The fifth precept, refraining from intoxicating drinks and drugs that lead to carelessness, is not accounted for here, but occasionally it is also not included in the very list of precepts (as in M III 47). See Gethin 2011: 194.
[16] Ibid 196-7.
[17] M I 55-63 and D II 290-315 respectively.

five hindrances, the five aggregates, the six sense-spheres, the seven awakening factors, and the four noble truths.

Finally, the eighth factor of the path, **right concentration** (*sammā-samādhi*), is explicated by reference to a stock description of the successive attainment of the four *jhānas*. This description, in its turn, is a condensed description of the Buddhist path, starting with the abandoning of the five hindrances, followed by the attainment of the six higher knowledges, understanding of the four noble truths, and the release of the mind from the most extreme form of mental defilements (*āsavas*).[18] And so we arrive where we started, deriving lists from the traditional treatment of the path—a process that might continue indefinitely.

This exercise of tracing the bare list of the noble eightfold path illustrates, as Gethin observes, "how one *Nikāya* list acts as a veritable matrix for a whole series of further lists. We may begin with one simple list, but the structure of early Buddhist thought dictates that we end up with an intricate pattern of lists within lists, which sometimes turns back on itself and repeats itself, the parts subsuming the whole."[19] Thus, more than a condensed summary, the *mātikā* is a seed, as it were, that begets doctrinal topics of the Buddha's teaching. It is the source of the Dhamma—a function reflected in the exact underlying figurative meaning of *mātikā/mātṛkā* qua "mother."

What we have here, therefore, is a feminine symbolism at the heart of *Theravāda* thought that goes back to as early as the *Nikāya*s, which normally do not easily lend themselves to feminist interpretations. This feminine symbolism becomes ever more powerful and complex in the *Abhidhamma*.

II. The *mātikā* in the *Abhidhamma*

In the four primary *Nikāya*s, most extensively in the *Aṅguttara* collection, and in the *Vinaya-piṭaka,* the term *mātikā* features as the first member of

[18] E.g., D I 62-84, 171-4, 206-9.
[19] Gethin 1992: 153.

the compound *mātikā-dhara,* itself part of the stock description of the accomplished, learned senior monk: "one who has heard much, one to whom the tradition has been handed down, the bearer of the teaching (*dhamma-dhara*), of the discipline (*vinaya-dhara*), and of the *mātikā* (*mātikā-dhara*)."[20] This implies that monks who pursued the study of the Buddha's teaching and were involved in the doctrinal elaboration on key concepts from his discourses were called "bearers of the *mātikā*."

Since the Buddha's teaching is represented most directly in the discourses that form the Suttas and his prescriptions for the lifestyle of the monks and nuns form the Vinaya, it seems that the sequence *dhamma vinaya mātikā* ought to correspond to the sequence of the three canonical collections, that is, the Sutta, Vinaya, and *Abhidhamma* "baskets" (*piṭaka*) respectively. *Abhidhamma* thought and literary style as reflected in the *Abhidhamma-piṭaka* support this surmise.[21]

Scholarly opinion has generally been divided between two alternative interpretations of the term *abhidhamma*, both of which hinge upon the denotation of the prefix *abhi*. First, taking *abhi* in the sense of "with regard to," *abhidhamma* is understood as a discipline whose subject matter is the Dhamma, or the Buddha's teaching. Second, using *abhi* in the sense of preponderance and distinction, *abhidhamma* has also been deemed a distinct, higher teaching: the essence of the Buddha's teaching or that which goes beyond what is given in the Buddha's discourses, in a sense somewhat reminiscent of the term "metaphysics."[22] Buddhist tradition itself differentiates between the Sutta and *Abhidhamma* methods of instructing the teaching by contrasting the Suttanta "way of putting things" in partial, conventional terms that require further clarification,

[20] E.g., D II 125; M I 221–3; A I 117, II 147 & 170, III 179–80; Vin I 119 & 337, II 98 & 229.

[21] The *Abhidhamma-piṭaka* preserves the worldview of a particular tradition ancestral to the Sinhalese Theravāda, namely, the Vibhajjavāda, which belonged to the Sthaviras. The Vibhajjavādins were able to spread out in Southern India and in parts of South-East Asia throughout the first century CE. On the history of the early Buddhist schools, see Mhv V 12–13; Cousins 1991: 27–8; Lamotte 1988: 271ff.

[22] E.g., Dhs-a 2–3; Horner 1941.

as opposed to the *Abhidhamma* exposition and catechism that expound the teaching fully, in non-figurative, "ultimate" terms.[23]

Abhidhamma literature consists of the canonical collection that includes seven treatises, as well as post-canonical commentaries on these works, and a variety of manuals that introduce and expound the canonical materials. The canonical treatises are the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī* ("Enumeration of dhammas"), the *Vibhaṅga* ("Analysis"), the *Dhātukathā* ("Discourse on Elements"), the *Puggalapaññatti* ("Designation of Persons"), the *Kathāvatthu* ("Points of Discussion"), the *Yamaka* ("Pairs"), and the *Paṭṭhāna* ("Conditions").[24]

These seven works manifest two literary characteristics: first, they analyze meticulously the significant points of the Dhamma by arranging them around *mātikās* of doctrinal topics. As we shall see presently, the *Abhidhamma mātikās* are much more elaborate and complex than the Suttanta *mātikās*. The resulting tabulation of these increasingly more complex *mātikās* paved the way for an infinite process of categorization of doctrinal concepts.[25] The second literary characteristic is that the *Abhidhamma* texts address various points of dispute that arise out of the abovementioned analytical project in a catechetical, argumentative style. This latter feature demonstrates the process of institutionalization undergone by Buddhist thought and its growing bent for discursive hermeneutics through catechetical exposition.

The two features of the *Abhidhamma* literary genre reflect two approaches to discussing the Dhamma that arose within the early Buddhist community: the first tended to summarize and analyze the significant points of the Buddha's teaching, the second to elaborate on and interpret the doctrines taught by means of monastic disputations.[26] The *Abhidhamma* treatises thus became a medium by which the

[23] A IV, 449–56; Vibh 100–1; Dhs-a 154.

[24] For a general survey of the Abhidhamma treatises see Frauwallner 1995: 43–87; von Hinüber 1997: 65–75; Norman 1983: 82ff.

[25] Cox 1995: 7–8; Frauwallner 1995: 3–6, 121–3 & 127.

[26] Cousins 1983: 10; Gethin 1992: 165. Thus, it would be too simplistic to say that the Abhidhamma treatises evolved solely out of the Suttanta *mātikās,* as the affinity between the two may well be the result of mutual influence. Abhidhamma-like activities may well have been extant during the time of the

Theravādins developed their position concerning the Dhamma through stimulating monastic debates with both their Buddhist rivals and Brahmanical opponents.

Within this increasingly scholastic environment, the Abhidhammikas were required to clarify their doctrinal concepts and define them in clear-cut theoretical terms. They had to analyze each item of the Buddha's discourses and then synthetically construct its relations to all other items so as to reveal its proper place within the teaching as a whole. Moreover, the evolving Buddhist tradition must have found the Suttanta method of ordering of doctrinal topics lacking and supported a shift towards a more formal practice of analyzing individual doctrinal principles. This practice, in its turn, facilitated a dramatic shift in the meaning of the concept of *dhamma*.

In the *Nikāya*s, both the singular and plural forms *dhamma/dhammas* interchangeably refer to the fundamental principles the Buddha taught, similarly to "teaching" and "teachings" in English.[27] In certain contexts, the singular form *dhamma* is used in the sense of "truth": the truth about the world or reality as directly experienced and taught by the Buddha.[28] Indeed, the Buddha's teaching is said to be effective because it is the truth about the underlying nature of reality, about the way things are.

Within the specific context of meditative contemplation, however, the plural *dhammas* signify both elements of the normative system prescribed by the Buddha's teachings and the objects that arise in a practitioner's consciousness while absorbed in insight meditation.[29] In particular, the plural form *dhammas* came to denote the objects of the six senses: that is, mental objects of the sixth sense faculty, *manas*, broadly translated as "mind," alongside the objects of the five ordinary physical senses.[30] As such, *dhammas* are not merely mental objects like thoughts,

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composition of the Suttas, whose final redaction overlaps with the composition of the Abhidhamma works. On this point, see Bronkhorst 1985: 318–19.

[27] S II 16 & 18; M I 133.

[28] E.g., D I 110; M I 380.

[29] M I 55 & D II 290; Collins 1982: 115.

[30] M III 62; S I 113 & 115–16, II 140ff, IV 114 & 163ff; A I 11.

ideas, or concepts, but a pluralistic representation of all encountered sensory phenomena; the phenomenal world in its entirety as we experience it through the senses.[31]

The canonical *Abhidhamma* treatises, especially the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* and the *Vibhaṅga,* emphasize the meaning of *dhammas* particularly as objects of *manas,* which here acquires a more formal sense of a specific discriminative consciousness, or rather mental cognitive awareness (*manoviññāṇa,* oftentimes translated literally as "mind-consciousness"), now deemed the central cognitive function within the process of sensory perception.[32] As the objects of mental cognitive awareness, *dhammas* can be rendered apperceptions: rapid consciousness-types (*citta*) that arise and cease in sequential streams, each having its own object, and that interact with the five sensory modalities of cognitive awareness as they arise in dependence on their corresponding material phenomena.

The canonical *Abhidhamma* portrays these *dhammic* apperceptions as diverse qualities or capacities of psychophysical events by means of which the mind unites and assimilates a particular perception, especially one newly presented, to a larger set or mass of ideas already possessed, thus comprehending and conceptualizing it. *Dhammas* are the basic qualities, both mental and physical, that constitute experience in its entirety; they are the units that make up reality—and in Buddhism this always means the world as experienced through the senses, within the scope of the five aggregates.[33]

For the *Abhidhamma*, then, *dhammas* are reckoned physical and mental qualities as presented in consciousness. The *Abhidhamma* turns this notion of the plurality of *dhammas* into the basis of an intricate theory of consciousness. It analyzes the *dhammas* meticulously, dividing them into a large number of categories. It does so by applying multiple *mātikās* that set out the basic categories of *dhamma* analysis. Two *mātikās* are particularly significant in this process: these are the twenty-two "tri-

[31] For a discussion of the range of meanings of *dhamma/s* in Theravāda, see Ronkin 2005: Chapter 2; Gethin 2004.
[32] E.g., Vibh 10, 14–15, 54, 60–2 & 71; Dhātuk 7–8, 34, 41, 63 & 67.
[33] Gethin 1998: 209–10; 2001: 149–50; 2004: 521.

plets" (*tika*) and one hundred "couplets" (*duka*) listed at the beginning of the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi*.[34] Scholars refer to these two key matrices as the *abhidhamma-mātikā.*

In addition to the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi*, the *abhidhamma-mātikā* informs the *dhamma* analysis in the *Vibhaṅga,* the *Dhātukathā,* and the *Paṭṭhāna*. The *Vibhaṅga* also employs three other *mātikās* and the *Paṭṭhāna* is built upon a *mātikā* of twenty-four relations of causal conditioning. The *Puggalapaññatti* has a straightforward *mātikā* that arranges the topics discussed by numerical progression. The *Kathāvatthu* and *Yamaka* are the only texts that do not have explicit *mātikās,* though the tradition considers their underlying discussion points and chapters as *mātikās*.[35] We may thus say that all seven *Abhidhamma* canonical treatises create a typology of *dhammas* based on *mātikās*.

Of all seven canonical *Abhidhamma* treatises, it is the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* that is especially important for the analysis of consciousness. Essentially, the whole *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* is a venture into the analysis of consciousness by explicating the *abhidhamma-mātikā*. Let us briefly consider how this is done.

Each triplet of the *abhidhamma-mātikā* comprises three categories for classifying *dhammas,* each couplet two such categories. As an example, some of the triplet categories include: *dhammas* that are skillful, unskillful, or undeclared; *dhammas* that are associated with happiness, with painful feeling, or with neutral feeling; *dhammas* that are results, that have resultant quality, or that are neither; *dhammas* that contain the first two *jhāna* factors of initial directing thought and sustained thought, that have sustained thought only, or that have neither; *dhammas* that have the past as their object, the present as their object, or the future as their object. And the list goes on.

Some of the couplet categories include: *dhammas* that are moral roots/motives, or that are not moral roots; *dhammas* that are motivated ("with moral roots") or that are unmotivated; *dhammas* that are causally related or that are not causally related; *dhammas* that are material or

[34] Dhs 1-7.
[35] Gethin 1992: 160.

that are immaterial; *dhammas* that are *āsavas* or that are not *āsavas; dhammas* that are associated with the *āsavas* or that are not associated with them; *dhammas* that are the hindrances or those that are not hindrances; *dhammas* that are associated to hindrances and those that are not; *dhammas* that are favorable to hindrances and those that are not; and so on.

It is immediately obvious that the categories of the *abhidhamma-mātikā* are all concerned with processes relevant to the Buddhist path to awakening, or to be more exact, with how the Buddhist path effects a transformation from the ordinary mind to the awakened mind. I shall have more to say on this in the next section. It is also equally clear that the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi*'s application of the complex *abhidhamma-mātikā* would result in an extremely intricate *dhamma* categorization that multiplies the number of possible *dhammas* almost indefinitely.

Informing this proliferation of *dhammas* is the figurative meaning of *mātikā* as "mother" with its underlying feminine symbolism as a creative source. The post-canonical tradition is well aware of this feminine symbolism. Consider the following explanation of Kassapa of Coḷa (c. 1200 CE), the author of the *Mohavicchedanī,* a commentary on the *mātikās* of the *Abhidhamma*, as cited and translated by Gethin:

> In what sense is it a *mātikā?* In the sense of being like a mother. For a *mātikā* is like a mother as a face is like a lotus. For as a mother gives birth to various different sons, and then looks after them and brings them up, so a *mātikā* gives birth to various different *dhammas* and meanings, and then looks after them and brings them up so that they do not perish. Therefore the word *mātikā* is used. For in dependence on the *mātikā,* and by way of the seven treatises beginning with the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi, dhammas* and meanings without end or limit are found as they are spread out, begotten, looked after and brought up, as it were, by the *mātikā*. [...] And looking after and bringing up here are to be understood as the bringing together and preserving of

the neglected and hidden meanings of the texts, having distinguished them by following the *mātikā*.[36]

Thus, the *mātikās* of the *Abhidhamma* are the "mother of all Dhamma/s." They beget the Dhamma in both its senses of the Buddha's teaching and of the truth about the way things are; the truth about the world or reality as directly realized and taught by the Buddha. Hence, as Kate Crosby observes, the *mātikā* is the creator of all *dhammas* qua the analytical components of reality.[37] Once again, at stake here is the *Theravāda*'s appropriation of a positive feminine symbol. Crosby shows that the *mātikā* is but one of a large number of examples that reveal that positive female and female-inclusive symbols are as available in *Theravāda* literature as they are in *Mahāyāna* and *Vajrayāna*. This range of examples, Crosby opines, undermines the characterization of *Theravāda* literature as more suppressive of women than *Mahāyāna* literature—"a proposition for which I find no basis," she says.[38]

The appropriation of the *mātikā* as a feminine symbol is not limited only to *Theravāda* doctrinal thought. Rather, it extends to *Theravāda* soteriology, particularly as it relates to the practice of meditation. In the following section I shall support this claim by focusing on the salvific aspect of the *mātikā* within the context of Buddhist meditation.

III. The *mātikā* and Buddhist Meditation

From its inception, Buddhism reminds us that we are constituted by how we respond to, interpret, perceive, and conceptualize our lived experience, and it founds itself on the observation that there is something fundamentally wrong and unsatisfactory with that experience. The Buddha teaches that to understand truly one's world as experienced is to see reality as it is: not a container of persons and "things," but rather an assemblage of interlocking physical and mental processes that spring up and pass away subject to multifarious causes and conditions.

[36] Moh 2-3 in Gethin 1992: 161.
[37] Crosby 2008: 40.
[38] Ibid., 44.

To understand the causes and conditions of this dynamism is to gain insight into the true nature of reality, which is equivalent to seeing *dhamma* (in its sense of "truth") and to liberating knowledge. The renowned statement "He who sees dependent arising sees *dhamma*, he who sees *dhamma* sees dependent arising"[39] clearly demonstrates this point.

It is through insight meditation that one cultivates wisdom that sees directly into reality as it is. Supporting this is the notion of the plural form *dhammas* we discussed above, as both elements of the Buddha's teachings and as the objects that arise in one's consciousness while absorbed in insight meditation. Thus, what appears in consciousness to a practitioner while absorbed in meditative attainment follows the patterns laid down by the Buddha's teachings. Training him/herself along the Buddhist path, a monk/nun moves from thinking about the teachings to thinking with them, as it were, for they are what makes up reality as taught by the Buddha.[40]

Moreover, as Gethin observes, seeing in meditation *dhammas* as they are—as causally conditioned physical and mental qualities that constantly arise and disappear—is to see the teaching and the ultimate truth. In this sense, to know the *dhamma* is to know *dhammas* in their various aspects.[41] This implies that the *mātikā*, the source of *dhammas*, is the creative principle that informs, both by exemplification and symbolically, the discrimination of *dhammas* and the wisdom that arises from that reflection.[42] I shall return to this point towards the end of this section.

This salvific aspect of the *mātikā* is equally present in the *Abhidhamma*. As I already noted, for the *Abhidhamma*, *dhammas* are reckoned psychophysical occurrences or qualities as presented in consciousness. I also mentioned above that the *Abhidhamma* utilizes the *mātikās* to turn the notion of the plurality of *dhammas* into the basis of an intricate theory of consciousness. A glimpse into this theory will help clarify the role that the *mātikās* play in Buddhist soteriology and meditation.

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[39] M I 190–1.
[40] Gombrich 1996: 36–7; Collins 1982: 115.
[41] See Gethin 2001: 151-3 & 350-1; 2004, esp. p. 535-7.
[42] On this point, see Collins 1982: 109.

The tradition divides the *dhammas* into multiple categories or types of occurrence: *Pāli Abhidhamma* counts eighty-two categories. Eighty-one categories are conditioned, whereas the eighty-second *dhamma* category is unconditioned and has one single member, namely, nirvana. The eighty-one conditioned *dhammas* fall into three broad categories: the bare phenomenon of consciousness (*citta*), which encompasses a single *dhamma* type and of which the essential characteristic is the cognizing of an object; associated mentality (*cetasika*), which encompasses fifty-two *dhamma* types; and materiality or physical phenomena (*rūpa*), which include twenty-eight *dhammas* that make up all physical occurrences.[43] The *Abhidhamma* analyzes in great detail each of these categories.

It is important to note, though, that it does not enumerate all existing *dhammas*, but rather analyzes those that appear in one's consciousness conditioned upon one's progression along the path to awakening. Each such occurrence represents an interlocking complex of phenomena made up of the appropriate type of *citta,* a number of necessary *cetasikas,* and various kinds of material phenomena. I shall focus here particularly on the analysis of *citta* and its utilization of the *mātikā.*

The paradigm for the operation of *citta* is *citta* as experienced in the process of sensory perception. *Citta* can never be experienced as bare consciousness in its own origination moment, for consciousness is always intentional, directed to some particular object that is cognized by means of certain mental factors. Hence *citta* always occurs associated with its appropriate *cetasika*s or mental factors that perform diverse functions and that emerge and cease together with it, having the same object (either sensuous or mental) and grounded in the same sense faculty. Any given consciousness moment—also signified by the very term *citta*—is thus a unique assemblage of *citta* and its associated mental factors such as feeling, conceptualization, volition, or attention, to name several of those required in any thought process.

The classic *Abhidhamma* scheme—developed by the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* but organized by the commentarial tradition—describes

[43] Abhidh-av 1.

eighty-nine types of consciousness moments, i.e., assemblages of *citta* and *cetasika*.[44] It begins with the sense-sphere (*kāmāvacara*), which includes unskillful consciousnesses at the bottom, followed by consciousnesses that concern the mechanics of bare awareness of the objects of the five senses, and then by skillful consciousnesses; next come various form-sphere (*rūpāvacara*) and formless-sphere (*arūpāvacara*) consciousnesses that constitute the *jhānas;* finally, there are world-transcending (*lokuttara*) consciousnesses that constitute the mind at the moment of awakening itself: these have nirvana as their object.

The *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* analyzes each of these categories by applying the *abhidhamma-mātikā.* Following the first triplet of the *mātikā,* the text opens with explicating the nature of consciousness types that are skillful and produce good karma, those that are unskillful and produce bad karma, and those that are undeclared and produce no karma. It then further categorizes *citta* by systematically exploiting the *mātikā*'s numerous variables.

Consider, for instance, some of the questions pertaining to the unskillful consciousness types: What are the *dhammas* that are impure and defiling? What are the *dhammas* that are to be abandoned by mental cultivation? What are the *dhammas* that are to be abandoned by insight? What are the *dhammas* whose causes are to be abandoned by mental cultivation? What are the *dhammas* that are inferior, mediocre, or excellent? What are the *dhammas* that are bound up with what is wrong? And so on.[45] The lengthy list of questions multiplies the number of possible *dhamma* types almost indefinitely.

These, albeit they all fall into one of the broad categories of skillful, unskillful, or undeclared, differ from one another in their quality and efficacy. Thus, the entire *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* is an inquiry into the distinctions between instances of *citta* based on the differences in their quality and efficacy. This treatise is, first and foremost, soteriological: it reveals the ways in which consciousness operates and fuels its continuation from

[44] Dhs 9-124; Vism XIV 81–110; Abhidh-av 1–15; Abhidh-s 1–5.
[45] Dhs 184.

the past, to the present, and into the future, thus elucidating the noble truths of the origin and cessation of *dukkha*.

Rather than an exhaustive inventory of the *dhammas* that exist "out there," the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* is an investigation into the workings of the mind. Its *dhamma* typologies constitute a map, as it were, of the objects of thought that may possibly arise in consciousness as one progresses on the Buddhist path to awakening. The attempt is not to reveal the absolute number of *dhammas* in their totality, but to know fully what goes on in the mind when one tries to train it. Thus, the *dhamma* categorizations deriving from the *abhidhamma-mātikā* function as basic schemes for practical purposes of exposition.

The ways in which the tradition deliberately supports the proliferation of categorization schemes and of their resulting *dhamma* types shows that they are not meant to be final or absolute. In fact, even the developed categorization of eighty-nine *citta* types is not regarded as ultimate. For instance, in the post-canonical literature, we see an alternative schema of one hundred and twenty-one *cittas*,[46] and the *Abhidhammāvtāra,* an Abdhidhamma manual ascribed to Buddhadatta (c. 430 CE), shows how the eight types of actively skillful *cittas* of the sense-sphere proliferate into 17,280 types when subject to additional classifications.[47] The same practice can equally be applied to other *citta* types.

To characterize this method as mere scholasticism is to miss the point about the *Abhidhamma*'s pragmatic concern with the path to awakening and with practical psychology. Just like the *Nikāya*s, the *Abhidhamma* analyzes sentient experience in order to facilitate insight into the nature of that experience as impermanent (*anicca*) and not self (*anattā*).[48] Accordingly, the *mātikās* and the *dhamma* typologies that are born out of them are conducive to Buddhist meditation. They are meant to be meditated upon, rather than read, in order to cultivate mindfulness and directly see impermanence and not self.

[46] Abhidh-av 29; Abhidh-s 5.
[47] Abhidh-av 4.
[48] Gethin 2001 discusses this extensively (see, for instance, p. 351). See also Ronkin 2005: chapters 4 & 5.

Ultimately, one has to move beyond merely applying to one's experience the eighty-nine types of consciousness, or twenty-four causal conditions, or twelve links of dependent origination, or five aggregates. The point is to gain insight into the principle that all encountered phenomena are conditioned, and by that token unsatisfactory, and by that token not self. Seeing this is but gaining wisdom that understands the four noble truths, which is equal to transforming one's ordinary mind into the awakened mind of Buddhas and *arahants*.[49]

The *dhamma* typologies are intentionally open-ended and the tradition supports their proliferation based on complex *mātikās,* showing that there are no ultimate entities, because all experienced phenomena are always amenable to further division. By utilizing the *mātikās,* the *Abhidhamma* tradition encourages us to avoid too fixed a view of reality. The Buddha's teaching suggests that the fundamental problem of human existence results from emotionally and intellectually grasping at and fixing our experiential world. In order to put an end to this problem, we must break up the apparently solid and static world that we make up for ourselves. This, as Gethin claims, is what the *mātikās* are all about:

> Sometimes the texts suggest the world is to be analyzed and seen in terms of the five aggregates, or the twelve sense-spheres, or the eighteen elements; sometimes in terms of wholesome, unwholesome and indeterminate *dhammas* [...] In offering these different methods the texts seem to want to remind one that when the world is broken up into parts, these parts are not to be mistaken for inert lumps; they are moving parts and what is more they are parts that continuously change their shape and color depending on the perspective from which they are being viewed. [...] Try to grasp the world of the *Dhammasaṅgaṇi* and it runs through one's fingers. In short, the indefinite expansions based on the *mātikās* continually remind those using them that it is of the nature of things that no single way of breaking up and analyzing the world can ever be final.[50]

[49] See Collins 1982: 114-5; Gethin 1992: 164-5.
[50] Gethin, ibid.

The *mātikā,* then, as the "mother of all *dhammas,*" embodies and facilitates insight into the nature of things, into reality as it truly is. In this regard, as I previously mentioned, to know the *dhamma* is to know *dhammas* in their various aspects. In both the *Nikāyas* and *Abhidhamma*, this discrimination of *dhammas*/discernment of *dhamma* (*dhamma-vicaya*) is considered one of the "factors of awakening" (*bojjhaṅgas*) and corresponds with wisdom (*paññā* (*Pāli*)/*prajñā* (Sanskrit))—that is, salvific wisdom that knows the four noble truths.[51]

In her article "Gendered Symbols in *Theravāda* Buddhism," Crosby draws attention to the *Mahāyāna* notion of the ultimate embodiment of salvific wisdom, namely, "the perfection of wisdom" (*prajñāpāramitā*), the final proper understanding of the way things truly are. For the *Mahāyāna*, *prajñāpāramitā* is a feminine principle and is personified as the mother of Dharma (truth/teaching). Her object is emptiness (*śūnyatā*), which is the ultimate truth of how absolutely everything—including the *dharmas* of the *Abhidharma* analysis—is empty of inherent existence or essence, empty of self or anything pertaining to self.

This perfection of wisdom that understands reality as emptiness transforms the ordinary mind into the awakened mind of Buddhas and *arahants*. Hence *prajñāpāramitā* is "the mother of all Buddhas," as stated in the *Prajñāpāramitā Sūtra,* the basic text of all *Mahāyāna* schools.[52] Crosby then shrewdly observes: "We have, then, in *Abhidharma*, an exact parallel, indeed precursor, for the feminine *prajñāpāramitā* of *Mahāyāna*."[53]

Moreover, Crosby shows that not only was this feminine symbolism of the *mātikā* as mother of all *dhamma/s* the concern of the doctrinal portions of the *Nikāyas* or *Abhidhamma* texts, but that it also features in *Theravāda* myths and meditation practices, particularly those of a certain tradition in mainland Southeast Asia.

In the next and final section, I shall review some of the characteristics of this *Theravāda* tradition and the role of the *mātikā* in it.

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[51] E.g., S V 111, Dhs-11. See also Gethin 2001: 147 & 181.
[52] Crosby, 2008: 40.
[53] Ibid.

V. The *mātikā* in Tantric *Theravāda*

Crosby's numerous examples of positive feminine symbols in *Theravāda* literature challenge the surprisingly widespread notion of *Theravāda* as a rather uniform—if not monolithic—form of Buddhism. Indeed, scholars have shown the varieties of Southern Buddhism and its idiosyncrasies that are far removed from its standard portrayal as a purely rationalistic tradition.[54] My concern here is with a particular form of Southern Buddhism that scholars refer to as "esoteric" or "tantric," and that remains largely underrepresented in the field of Buddhist Studies.

This esoteric form of *Theravāda*, as L.S. Cousins notes, "is not the same as the more general practices of a magical kind which are as endemic in the Southern Buddhist countries as they were in Europe until quite recent times—in their local form involving the use of *yantra* or *mantra* and/ or ritual for purposes of protection, healing, harming, empowering and general assistance. Nor is it the same as the equally endemic trance-based ecstatic and mediumistic practices used for similar purposes." Rather, our concern here is with "a type of Southern Buddhism which links magical and ritual practices to a theoretical systematization of the Buddhist path itself."[55]

To date, studies of this tradition have focused on materials from Cambodia, but it is also found in Laos, Thailand, Burma, and, to a limited extent, even in Sri Lanka. It is difficult to determine the historical origins and scope of the tradition, particularly due to the rise to dominance of a reformed Buddhist school from the nineteenth century, and because of the devastation of Cambodian culture by the Khmer Rouge.

There is not even agreed terminology to refer to the tradition at stake and its materials. François Bizot, scholar of the École française d'Extrême-Orient, who has produced a series of studies that spearhead research into this area, speaks of the unreformed *Mahānikāya* or non-*Mahāvihāravāsin* tradition. Heinz Bechert refers to "tantric *Theravāda*," while Cousins prefers "esoteric Southern Buddhism." Crosby, on the other hand, speaks of the *yogāvacara* tradition—*yogāvacara* being a term that

[54] For a review of this scholarly discussion, see Cousins 1997: 188-9.
[55] Ibid 190.

recurs in the texts Bizot examines and that means "practitioner of spiritual discipline," i.e., a person undertaking the meditation practices advocated by the tradition at stake.

Like Crosby, I shall use here the term *yogāvacara*. For the following overview of this tradition, I shall refer to writings by Cousins, Crosby, and Ian Harris, who all build upon Bizot's series of studies.[56]

The esotericism of *yogāvacara*, as Cousins describes it, "is about mapping worlds, both visible and invisible ones." By this is meant a form of mysticism that uses a system of correspondences between the human body, the cosmos, and higher knowledge. *Yogāvacara* integrates this system of correspondences with the spiritual path and with traditions of ritual, magic, and the occult—letter, sound (mantras, sacred syllables), number symbolism, and breathing and visualization techniques.[57] All these aspects are applied to both the soteriological goal of the pursuit of *nibbāna* and to worldly ends, such as healing, longevity, or protection. Moreover, expertise in the tradition is not the sole purview of monks: rather, lay people, including women, may be practitioners as well as teachers to monks.[58]

Particularly important for our present concern with the *mātikā* is the way in which the *yogāvacara* systematizes the spiritual path. The tradition sees the Pāli canon—the vehicle of the Buddha's word—as the source of a sacred language whose syllables and terms embody the correspondences of microcosm, macrocosm, and the highest truth gained by practicing the spiritual discipline of meditation.

In this regard, consider "The Fig Tree with Five Branches," which Bizot first used to introduce *yogāvacara* material. This text is the *locus classicus* of prominent *yogāvacara* ideas and of symbolism of the spiritual path. In it we find a major correspondence the tradition draws

[56] I refer to Cousins' 1997 article "Aspects of Esoteric Southern Buddhism" as quoted above; to Crosby's 2000 review article "Tantric Theravāda: A Bibliographic Essay on the Writings of François Bizot and others on the Yogāvacara Tradition"; and to Harris (2005) *Cambodian Buddhism: History and Practice*.
[57] Cousins 195.
[58] Crosby 142.

between the fig tree with five branches and the human body: its trunk is the torso, its five branches the five senses (also the arms and legs), its leaves the two ears, its flower the umbilicus, its fruit the embryo. It is also a cosmic tree, stretching as high as the divine realms, with its roots in the infernal regions.[59]

Now the allegory extends further, expanding the correspondence of human form and the macrocosm to encompass higher knowledge of the spiritual path. For we are told that the tree—that is, our body with its five senses—"extends beyond the four continents" and "grows as high as is *nibbāna*."

The following passage, translated by Cousins from the French of Bizot, illustrates this point: "O Children of the Heart! In that place there is a fig tree with each of its fruits concealing a precious crystal sphere. It casts a delicious scent over countless world spheres. This is the holy Dhamma. The crystal sphere placed in the flowers of the fig tree—magnificent and glorious—this is the holy Buddha."[60] The fig tree with five branches, then, is both the human body and the Dhamma, in which hides the gem that is the Buddha.

This passage is part of a story in which a boy and a girl—representing here mentality and materiality (*nāma* and *rūpa* respectively), the constituents of the person in the round of rebirth—are told that the only way to escape death is to find the gem hidden in the fig tree. The search inside the tree—i.e., inside one's own body—is done through the spiritual practice of meditation. The *yogāvacara* text states that the essence of the gem hidden in one's body is the three syllables of the sacred sound AUM (=*oṃ*), which, in turn, correspond with the three "baskets" of the Pāli canon.

This shows how the Pāli syllables are understood as sacred sounds and *dhammas*: in the sense of elements of the Buddha's word, in the sense we discussed above, as physical and mental qualities that constitute sentient experience, and in the sense of the constituents of a

[59] Cousins, ibid 195-6.
[60] Ibid 196. Translated by Cousins from the French of Bizot.

universe built from sacred sound.[61] The following extract conveys these points:

> A PĀ MA CU PA – this is the quintessence of the five books of the holy *Vināya.*
>
> DI MAṂ SAṂ AṂ U – this is the quintessence of the five books of the holy *Suttanta.*
>
> SAṂ VI DHĀ PU KA YA PA – this is the quintessence of the seven books of the holy *Abhidhamma.*
>
> A is the holy *Ādikamma;* PĀ is the holy *Pācittiya;* MA is the holy *Mahāvagga;* CU is the holy *Cūlavagga;* PA is the holy *Parivāra.* These are the names of the holy *Vinaya.*
>
> DI is the holy *Dīghanikāya;* MAṂ is the holy *Majjhimanikāya;* SAṂ is the holy *Saṃyuttanikāya;* AṂ is the holy *Aṅguttaranikāya;* U is the holy *Khuddakanikāya.* These are the names of the five books of the holy *Suttanta.*
>
> SAṂ is the holy [*Dhamma*]*Saṅgaṇi;* VI is the holy *Vibhaṅga;* DHĀ is the holy *Dhātukathā;* PU is the holy *Puggalapaññatti;* KA is the holy *Kathāvatthu;* YA is the holy *Yamaka;* PA is the holy *Mahāpaṭṭhāna.* These are the names of the seven books of the holy *Abhidhamma*.
>
> MA – i.e. *passāsa,* breathing expels and draws in, first *jhāna;*
>
> A – i.e. *assāsa,* absence of breathing, second *jhāna;*
>
> U – i.e. *nissāsa,* breathing expels, third *jhāna.*[62]

It comes as no surprise that the *mātikās* of the *Abhidhamma* play a significant role in this process of mapping the visible and invisible worlds through letter, sound, and number symbolism. For, as we have seen above, *mātikās* are mother-lists that beget *Dhamma/dhammas,* thus outlining the map to one's world(s). Indeed, one of the distinctive features of the *yogāvacara* tradition is the significance it attributes to the

[61] Crosby 146; Harris 100 & 102; Cousins 199.
[62] Cousins 196-7.

texts of the *Abhidhamma-piṭaka* and to the *mātikās*.[63] Now let us bear in mind that it is through meditative practice that one cultivates wisdom that sees the truth (*Dhamma*) about one's world as it really is, in terms of *dhammas*. Accordingly, the *yogāvacara* especially highlights the importance of the *mātikās* within the context of meditation.

A major *yogāvacara* meditation practice is to internalize *dhammas* qua qualities and attributes of the path to Buddhahood. Here *yogāvacara* assimilates the experiences of meditation to the process of gestation, relating the stages of embryonic development to their corresponding Pāli syllables qua sacred formulae and *dhammas*.[64] This assimilation of the stages of embryonic development with their equivalent *dhammas* enacts a spiritual rebirth by which the practitioner transforms his/her body and creates a new one out of *dhammas*.

To create this special *dhamma*-body (*dhammakāya*), the practitioner applies visualization practices, imitating the body of the Buddha by visualizing the marks of the Great Man, thus creating "a Buddha within," in the region of the navel. The practitioner does it by visualizing *dhammas* as quasi-physical constituents that enter the nostril and pass down inside the body—a practice at the core of which are mindfulness of breathing exercises (*ānāpānasati*).[65] To actuate this process, the practitioner meditates on various *Abhidhamma mātikās*. Consider the following passage, again translated by Cousins from the French of Bizot:

> Add together the virtues of the mother and father, which makes thirty-three. This then is called the thirty-three letters which create all human beings.
>
> Add the thirty-three letters to the five aggregates, and one obtains the thirty-eight virtues of the holy Dhamma. This is the holy Dhamma in person.
>
> Take NA MO BU DDHĀ YA –
>
> NA, the twelve virtues of the mother;

[63] Crosby 142.
[64] Ibid 146; Cousins 200-1.
[65] Crosby 148-9 and 169-70; Harris 101.

MO, the twenty-one virtues of the father;

BU, the six virtues of the king;

DDHĀ, the seven virtues of the family;

YA, the ten virtues of the teacher.

These are the five aggregates which give the fifty-six virtues of the holy Buddha. This is the holy Buddha in person.

Combine the three: *passāsa, assāsa* and *nissāsa* [breathing in, breathing out, absence of breathing] with SAṂ VI DDHĀ PU KA YA PA and with the four elements NA MA A U. One obtains the fourteen virtues of the holy *saṅgha.* This is the holy *saṅgha* in person.

Adding all of these together gives 108.

This is found in our body. This is that which all noble sons, all people, all men, must seek to find and understand completely clearly.[66]

As this passage exemplifies, *yogāvacara* makes extensive use of *mātikās* to reinforce correspondences between the sacred Pāli syllables and the qualities (*guṇa*) of the Triple Gem, particularly of the Buddha. The passage highlights the tradition's main practice of internalizing various "mother-lists" of qualities and attributes of the path to create a -*dhamma*-body and a Buddha inside the practitioner's own body.

Thus, as Crosby notes, *Theravāda* "has practices akin to *Tathāgatagarbha* and *Vajrayāna* that use a range of meditation practices and ritual enactments to create a Buddha within."[67] *Tathāgatagarbha* teaches that an embryonic Buddha lies within each of us, meaning that Buddhahood is accessible to all, male and female alike, while *Vajrayāna* presents a method of ritual enactment of enlightenment enabling Buddhahood in a single lifetime, whether from a male

[66] Cousins 197-8.
[67] Crosby 2008: 43.

or female embodiment. Both *Tathāgatagarbha* and *Vajrayāna* have therefore been seen as productive sources for feminist interpretations of Buddhism.

Our foregoing discussion of the appropriation of the *mātikā* as a feminine symbol in both mainstream and esoteric *Theravāda* thought and practice points to the richness and diversity of *Theravāda* and supports the argument that this multifaceted tradition, too, may well be a fruitful source for recovering feminist Buddhist readings.

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Buddhism & Ageing: In Praise of Ageing

JETSUNMA TENZIN PALMO

The Lord Buddha defined *dukkha* or suffering as birth, old age, sickness and death. Since - if we do not die young - we are all going to experience old age and death, this is a topic that concerns everyone.

In our contemporary society there is the cult of youth and a denial of the natural course of life towards decay and death. Most people hope to keep looking young and beautiful – indeed beauty is usually associated with youthfulness. So there are endless books and articles on how to keep old age at a distance and stay young forever. But however many facelifts we undergo or exercise and diet regimes we submit to, eventually the body will deteriorate and the likelihood of sickness will increase. This is the nature of all conditioned things. In fact Buddhism faces up to the unpalatable facts of life and death – and even uses those facts as the path itself to transcend birth and death.

In more traditional societies the advent of ageing is seen as natural and not regarded as something to be avoided and denied for as long as possible. Rather, there is an appreciation that having lived for so long there should likewise be a growth of knowledge and understanding. So old age is often equated with wisdom and experience. The older members of the family are accorded respect and often assume the roles of councilors and guides. They have an important role to play within their society.

Even in the West there is the archetypal character of the wise old woman (as well as the witch) and most storybook wizards are elderly. Indeed old wrinkled faces with eyes shining with love and intelligence often display the real beauty.

Unfortunately - even though nowadays women over the age of 50 make up the majority of the population - in our modern social order the elderly are increasingly shunted aside, isolated among their senior

contemporaries and ignored by the world around them. It is considered that their useful days are finished and they have no further contribution to make to society. As a result old age is something to be dreaded and evaded for as long as possible.

So the question remains, how do we deal with our inevitable ageing in a way that makes sense of our life? In traditional Buddhist countries it is the custom that as our children grow up and leave home; as our professional lives wind down; and as our outgoing activities become more inwardly directed, that we give more attention to the Dharma and to setting our lives in order so as to be ready for death and future rebirths.

In traditional Buddhist societies many older people take the 8 precepts and pass their time in meditation or other meritorious activities such as circumambulation of holy objects, prostrations, chanting and visiting temples etc. The focus of their life is directed towards the Dharma and their devotion is cultivated. Thus their lives remain meaningful and important even as the axis of focus shifts.

For women in particular it often happens that our youth is taken up with acting out the roles that society has determined for us: firstly as physical objects of desire who must strive to be as attractive and alluring as possible to fulfill male fantasies. Then the wife and mother, devoted to nurturing her family and home. Nowadays most women also have full time careers in which they must work hard to keep ahead. It is a stress-filled lifestyle designed to meet the expectations of others.

However even in the modern world we are seeing an interesting phenomenon occur where many people – especially women – having fulfilled their life's tasks as wives, mothers and in their professional careers, are now ready to give their attention to more introvert callings such as the arts, the alternative healing professions, psychology and the study and practice of spiritual paths. Since these women are usually highly educated and motivated they are able to acquire new skills and extend a positive outreach into the society around them. Rather than spending their declining years merely playing golf or watching TV, their inner spiritual world is now given greater prominence.

A while back I met a group of women living in an affluent small town in Florida, who were devoting their later years to sincere spiritual practices and to philanthropic activities benefitting not only their own neighbourhood but also reaching out to other cultures and lands. They felt happy and fulfilled to be using their time for the benefit of others as well as themselves.

Many people I know have remarked that the latter part of their lives has become even more satisfying and meaningful than their earlier years. Now they can discover their own genuine interests rather than merely conforming to societal expectations. They feel that they have finally found the reason for their lives – although they also accept that the previous years were necessary for what has developed later. Like a tree that grows slowly and only in time can reveal its true characteristics. It seems that the foremost regret expressed by those who are dying is: "I wish I'd had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me."

Of course most of us would prefer a 25 year old body but few would choose to return to our 25 year old mind! So instead of dreading the approach of old age – despite its accompanying loss of physical and mental flexibility – we can welcome this new stage of life and explore its potential. We have the choice whether to view our ageing as the gradual fading of all our dreams or to regard retirement as the start of a new and exciting era.

As we grow older we see our contemporaries - our friends and family members - succumbing to illnesses and death - so we are forced to recognise these states as natural and inevitable. As Buddhist women, we have an important part to play in demonstrating an alternative lifestyle which is not so dependant on our usual societal roles and can show the way forward to greater freedom and a more meaningful way of living. Even if our old knees ache too much for sitting cross-legged and our health issues keep us physically less active, our minds can still be bright and clear. Our meditation can deepen and mature.

Now that we have more time for ourselves we can select a lifestyle that is meaningful and engaging – exploring spiritual pathways and

reaching out in social engagement, thus benefitting ourselves and likewise benefitting others. This is a great opportunity to garner the skills acquired over our lifetime and put them to good use. We are reborn to a new life without yet having to discard the old one!

So it is that many people chose to travel or learn new skills, sports or crafts once their 'official' work and responsibilities are at an end. The question we can ask ourselves as Buddhists is "Now that my worldly responsibilities are fulfilled, how can I use this life most practically to be of help to myself and others? What needs to be done to make some more advances on the Dharma path?" This may not necessarily include long retreats or total immersion in Buddhist community work. There are many ways to develop ourselves and tame our mind. Usually as we grow older, the storms of emotional upheavals have quieted, we have some basic self-knowledge and perhaps our formal practice has also deepened over the years. Now we have the time and space to nurture these Bodhi saplings of our practice towards fruition and to encourage this Bodhi tree to realize its full potential.

For many ageing Buddhists there is also the issue of where to live as our faculties decline. As the family nucleus shrinks and is unable to offer home facilities, many older people, especially in the West but also increasingly in Asian countries, must face the probability of living their later years in a Nursing Home. To end up continually surrounded by people and care-givers who have no interest in spiritual matters, can be a very gloomy prospect. Therefore there is sometimes talk of starting some sort of Retirement Homes for Senior Buddhists – usually regardless of any particular tradition. Probably the main problem is financial since acquiring suitable land and buildings plus the subsequent upkeep would require considerable investment. However it would be a very worthwhile endeavor and surely requires more thought and attention.

So it is important to make good use of our later years - while our faculties are still functioning even if our physical vigour is declining. Finally it is up to us to take the life we have been given and make the most of our opportunities to develop our potential. This precious human body is precious because we are using it as a means to develop the mind

and advance along the path. Let us use our days to create the circumstances by which we can die without regrets.

Sometimes as we age we can become very ill with life threatening diseases such as cancer or heart problems. This is common. Many people look on the onset of such sickness with dread and horror and hope to die quietly in their sleep with no prior warning. However it is not always such an advantage to pass on without any preparation.

When we know in advance that our allotted time here is limited - even though this is actually true for all of us - it allows us the opportunity to make arrangements for leaving this life in an orderly and satisfactory manner. Knowing that we are truly going to die and the time is running out, can focus the mind wonderfully on what is important and what is *not* important. People are so often ***transformed*** as they begin to finally let go of their attachments and their long-held resentments in readiness to pass on.

This is the chance to reconcile our differences, repair broken relationships, and allow those whom we hold dear to know that they are loved and appreciated. In the face of our imminent mortality, we have nothing to lose but our hang-ups.

At the point of death it is best to focus the mind on one's personal practice or object of devotion. Or at least try to concentrate on light and absorb oneself into that. The people surrounding the dying person should remain calm and supportive, not giving way to grief, but perhaps gently chanting something appropriate.

On the whole if one has led a fairly decent life - and especially if one has made some effort to merge the Dharma with one's mind, then death holds no fears. The consciousness will follow along its accustomed path. So it is vital to make sure - while we still have some control over our thoughts and emotions - that this will be a pathway we would wish to travel.

As Professor Dumbledore advised young Harry Potter, "For one with a well-organised mind, death is but the next great adventure."

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With articles by:
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